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About the Author

Luke Johnston has given years of study to the subject of Bible versions and the history of the Bible. He holds a Doctor of Educational Ministry degree, but most importantly, received his Bible training through the God-ordained authority of the local church. His mindset, training, and, above all, his faith in the Word of God were formed through the instruction he received within his church. From that foundation, he went on to pursue advanced degrees from accredited institutions. He has found, however, that while these institutions are not ordained of God and often fall into apostasy, they also have a tendency to take the Word of God out of the hands of men, whereas the local church has always done the exact opposite. The church instilled in him a steadfast faith in Scripture and gave him both the training and the desire to defend its authority and preservation. It is out of that conviction, and with a burden to strengthen the faith of others, that he has written this book, to contend for the King James Bible as the preserved and perfect Word of God.

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GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Inspiration (incl. “given by inspiration of God”) — God’s direct, supernatural action by which the biblical writers received and accurately wrote down His revelation; as God’s own “breath,” this act is inseparable from His ongoing preservation of those words.

Plenary (Plenary Inspiration) — The view that inspiration extends to the entire Bible in full, *not* just parts of it; Scripture is wholly inspired in its totality.

Inerrant / Inerrancy — That the Scriptures are without error in what they affirm.

Infallible / Infallibility — That Scripture, as the product of the God who cannot lie, cannot fail or mislead; it is wholly trustworthy in all it teaches.

Original autographs — The first manuscripts penned by the biblical authors (or their authorized scribes), the initial physical writings from which copies were made.

Preservation (of Scripture) — God’s providential safeguarding of His words through history so that His people continue to possess His Word; tied to His unchangeable nature and promises.

Purification (of God’s Word) — The refining of God’s words (Ps. 12:6), applied to the historical process by which God’s Word is kept pure and recognized among His people.

"**Jot and tittle**" — Hebrew's smallest letter and smallest stroke of the pen; Jesus used these terms to show that even the minutest marks of the Law stand under God's guarantee.

Textual criticism — The scientific/scholarly effort to identify the best text of Scripture from surviving witnesses. The method of determining "What did the original authors say?"

Masoretic Text (MT) — The traditional Hebrew text preserved by Jewish scribes (Masoretes) using rigorous copying controls; represents the conservatively guarded OT used among the Jews.

Dead Sea Scrolls (and 1QIsa^{a} / Isaiah B) — Pre-Christian Hebrew manuscripts from Qumran that substantially align with the Masoretic tradition; the Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa^{a}) and the "Isaiah B" scroll closely match the MT.

Septuagint (LXX) — A collective label for ancient Greek renderings of the OT; earliest complete forms appear centuries after the alleged 3rd-century B.C. origin story and include Apocrypha, reflecting Alexandrian influence rather than a single unified pre-Christian edition.

Apocrypha (OT apocryphal content) — Jewish religious writings not recognized as inspired Scripture; in later Greek codices they are intermingled with canonical books, which is one reason those codices are viewed critically in these materials.

Textus Receptus (TR) / Received Text / Traditional Text — The predominant Greek NT tradition used for the

Authorized Version; the label “Textus Receptus” became standard after the 1633 Elzevir edition. (Also called Majority, Traditional, Byzantine, or Antiochan.)

Byzantine / Majority Text (Antioch line) — The widely attested NT text-form represented in the vast majority of Greek manuscripts and aligned with the traditional text used in the churches.

Alexandrian Text (Alexandria line) — A divergent text-type associated with Alexandria and figures like Origen; championed in codices such as Vaticanus (B) and Sinaiticus (א).

Critical Text (Nestle–Aland / UBS) — The modern eclectic (melting pot, combination of all manuscripts) Greek editions of the NT (e.g., NA/UBS) that rely heavily on Alexandrian witnesses such as Vaticanus and Sinaiticus and function as the base for most contemporary translations.

Codex Vaticanus (B) — A 4th-century uncial manuscript prioritized by modern editors; notable for significant omissions and for containing apocryphal material alongside Scripture.

Codex Sinaiticus (א / Aleph) — A 4th-century uncial manuscript discovered at St. Catherine’s, extensively corrected and often at variance with Vaticanus; also includes non-canonical works.

Codex Alexandrinus (A) — A 5th-century manuscript from Alexandria; mixed in character (Byzantine in the Gospels, Alexandrian elsewhere).

Lectionaries — Books arranged for public reading of selected Scripture passages in churches.

Uncials / Minuscules (Greek manuscript categories) — Uncials use large, continuous capital letters; minuscules are later manuscripts written in smaller, cursive-style script.

Patristic quotations / Church Fathers — Citations of Scripture found in early Christian writers, used as external witnesses in establishing the text.

Peshitta (Syriac) — The standard Syriac translation of the Bible used by eastern churches; recognized in these materials as supporting the traditional/Byzantine stream.

Old Latin / Vulgate — Early Latin translations ("Old Latin") pre-dating Jerome; the Vulgate is Jerome's later Latin revision.

INTF (Institut für Neutestamentliche Textforschung) manuscript counts — The German institute that catalogs Greek NT manuscripts; recent counts cited here estimate roughly 5,700–5,800 Greek witnesses.

Formal (Verbal) Equivalence — A translation method aiming for close, word-for-word rendering from the source language, preserving original structure and terms as much as possible.

Dynamic (Functional) Equivalence — A meaning-for-meaning approach that prioritizes conveying the thought of the original in natural target-language phrasing rather than mirroring each original word; contrasted with formal equivalence.

FOR FULL SIZES OF THE CHARTS IN THIS BOOK,
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WHY THIS BOOK, THOUGH OTHERS EXIST

Some may ask why another book on this subject is needed when shelves already hold volumes that argue for the same conclusion. The answer lies in both method and aim.

1. **Concise yet thorough.** Many books that defend the King James Bible stretch on for hundreds more pages than necessary. Their arguments are often weighed down by commentary, tangents, or extended narrative. While such material may have value in its own place, this book is designed to be “straight over the plate.” It says what needs to be said, no less, no more. The goal is to be concise and yet thorough. There are plenty of “weeds” to get into in this subject that are well worth exploring. For these areas, I have provided a recommended reading list at the end.

2. **Documented carefully.** Another weakness found in similar works is the lack of clear documentation. Some provide little to no citation for key claims; others reference sources in ways that are vague or confusing. In contrast, this book points you directly to the evidence. Every crucial statement is accompanied by traceable documentation so that you can verify the key information on this subject. Also, it uses original

sourcing wherever possible. Another common trait found in other writings on this subject is that you find "biased" sources list. In this book I tried to avoid this wherever possible.

3. **Up to date.** Some of the best-known works on this topic were written fifty years ago or more. In the time since, hundreds of manuscripts have been catalogued, new archaeological finds have come to light, and much has changed in the field. This book accounts for the most recent data without discarding the proven testimony of earlier witnesses.

4. **Built on faith, not just evidence.** Many defenders of the King James Bible present strong factual cases but build their argument on the wrong foundation. They start with human reasoning and work their way toward faith. This book takes the opposite path: it begins with the promises of God's Word and lets the evidence follow in its proper place. The structure is deliberately Scripture first, history second. Without that order, even good conclusions will falter under the right challenge.

5. **Not a "pseudo-King James" position.** A final distinction must be made here. Some of the most respected voices in this debate ultimately rest their authority in the Greek Textus Receptus rather than in the King James Bible itself. This opens the door to

problems, since there are multiple printed TR editions with notable differences amongst themselves. That position leaves the believer without a final authority. This book does not take that path. It contends unapologetically that the King James Bible itself is the purified, preserved Word of God in English.

6. **Charts and visual aids**. These are used to assist in grasping otherwise difficult to understand concepts.

7. **Balanced tone.** Some books on this topic come across harsh, attacking anyone who disagrees. Others are so soft that they never make a clear stand. This book tries to avoid both extremes wherever possible by speaking plainly and dealing in the facts of the matter.

INTRODUCTION

The pastor's voice rang out as he lifted his Bible high above the pulpit. "This is the Word of God! Infallible, inerrant, inspired! Trust it with your life, trust it with your eternity!" The congregation erupted with "Amens." Pens underlined words. Children were nudged to listen closely.

A young man sat three rows back; his own Bible open on his lap. He heard the pastor preaching about trusting every word. He believed him, but weeks later, in a membership class, he was handed the church's doctrinal statement. He scanned it until one line stopped him cold:

"We believe the Scriptures are inspired, inerrant, and infallible, in the original autographs."

His stomach dropped. He read it again. *The originals?* Scrolls written two thousand years ago and long since turned to dust? He looked down at the book in his lap, the one the pastor had waved in the air and called "the Word of God." Suddenly his mind began to race. *If this Bible isn't really inerrant, then what am I holding?*

He thought of the **safety instructions at the steel mill** where his father worked. If those manuals were "mostly right," men lost fingers. If even one warning line was

missing, the furnace could claim a life. He thought of the **prescription label** on his mother's medicine. If it was "accurate in the original notes from the lab," but the copy in the bottle was flawed, what good was it? *One wrong word and the dose could kill.* He thought of his younger brother learning to read from a **phonics chart**. If some of the words were off, just one letter dropped or changed, the whole foundation would be warped. How could he ever learn the language if he couldn't trust the chart?

And now here he was, being told to trust his eternity, not his body, not his job, not even his brother's reading, but his *soul*, to a book his own church admitted was not truly infallible. The young man stared at his Bible and asked the question that would not leave him:

If the Word of God is only perfect in manuscripts that vanished thousands of years ago, what am I really holding in my hands today?

The Real Issue at Stake

When people debate Bible translations, the talk usually slides into preferences: Which reads easier? Which sounds smoother? Which sells better? Those are side issues. The first questions we have to face are these:

Has God preserved His words, or not? Does a perfect word of God exist today? And if it does, where can I find it?

Wesley Huff, a well-known voice on manuscripts and textual criticism (M.A. in Theological Studies; Ph.D. candidate in Theological Studies and Sacred and Canonical Texts, NT concentration), was asked in 2025 whether a perfect Bible exists. His reply,[1]

> "I don't know if I'd use the word 'perfect' because that's kind of a tricky word. The word perfect implies flawless…"

If inspiration is true but perfect preservation of every word is false, then what makes the Bible unique from other books? If God gave His words and then lost them in the sands of Egypt or the vaults of Rome, then His promises ring hollow. But if He both inspired *and preserved* His words, then we can know with certainty that we can have access to the very words of God.

This book is not made for mere academic sparring over manuscripts, methods, lineages, etc.. but to instill faith back in the word of God. For *"faith cometh by hearing, and*

[1] "Part 1: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," Cultish (YouTube video), January 8, 2025, 56:00, posted by Cultish TV, hOps://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yLGTS6Q82kE.

hearing by the word of God" (Rom. 10:17). If the Word is unstable, faith is unstable. If the Word is sure, faith is sure.

Why This Book

This book is not written to score points in debates, nor to stir division among believers. It is written to strengthen faith. It is written for the plowboy Tyndale dreamed of when he said,[2]

> *"I defy the pope and all his laws … if God spare my life ere many years, I will cause a boy that driveth the plough, shall know more of the scripture then thou dost."*

It is for the ordinary Christian who wants to hold in his hands the very words of God, without doubt. Tyndale again spoke against the "scholarship" of his day and their tendency to take the word of God out the hands of common men when he said,[3]

> "In the universities they have ordained that no man shall look on the Scripture until he be nuzzled in

[2] John Foxe, *Actes and Monuments* (London: John Day, 1563), 570.

[3] William Tyndale, *The Practice of Prelates, in Expositions and Notes on Sundry Portions of the Holy Scriptures, Together with The Practice of Prelates*, ed. Henry Walter, Parker Society (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1849), 291.

heathen learning eight or nine years, and armed with false principles with which he is clean shut out of the understanding of the Scripture."

This book is written to show that preservation and purification are not theories; they are promises kept from God himself.

In the pages that follow, we will:

1. Build from the ground up with Scripture's own teaching on inspiration, preservation, and purification.
2. Trace the two lines of manuscripts and versions: Antioch and Alexandria.
3. Look at the Old Testament evidence (Masoretic Text, Dead Sea Scrolls, Septuagint).
4. Look at the New Testament evidence (manuscripts, early versions, fathers, the Alexandrian cluster).
5. Deal with the doctrinal places where modern versions keep softening the truth.
6. Clear away the myths about readability, revisions, the Apocrypha, and Erasmus.
7. Answer major objections.
8. Conclude with a call back to a FAITH BASED VIEW of the Bible: God has kept His Word, every word, for us today

The Bible is not just a book, it is the Book. It is the foundation for all doctrine, the sword in all spiritual warfare, the seed of all revival, it is everything we need for life and godliness (2 Pet. 1:3). The central question before us is not whether man has been faithful in guarding it, he has not. The question is whether God has been faithful in keeping His promise to preserve it. This book contends He has. And that preserved Word, for the English-speaking world, is the King James Bible.

INSPIRATION: WHAT GOD DID ONCE

When it comes to the inspiration of Scripture, Christians have for almost all time been in major agreement. When we talk about the inspiration of the Bible, inspiration literally means “God-breathed.” Inspiration is discussing the idea of the original writing, or the original penning of the words of Scripture, as the Holy Ghost moved men.

We see this in such verses as 2 Peter 1:21, which says:

> “For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.”

Another very popular verse that comes up when it comes to inspiration is 2 Timothy 3:15–17:

> “And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus. All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God

> may be perfect, throughly furnished unto all good works."

David testified of this process in 2 Samuel 23:2:

> *"The Spirit of the LORD spake by me, and his word was in my tongue."*

Notice the clarity: David did not say that God gave him the gist of an idea, but that the Spirit Himself placed the very words on his tongue.

The prophet Jeremiah spoke the same truth:

> *"Then the LORD put forth his hand, and touched my mouth. And the LORD said unto me, Behold, I have put my words in thy mouth"* (Jer. 1:9).

These men understood that what flowed from their lips was not their invention, but God's words.

The Lord Jesus Christ Himself confirmed this view of inspiration. In Matthew 22:43–44, when debating the Pharisees, He rooted His argument on a single word from Psalm 110:

> *"How then doth David in spirit call him Lord…?"*

Christ based the entire doctrine of His Lordship on the Spirit's exact wording through David. He did not treat Scripture as a general thought but as though every word mattered.

In Hebrews 3:7 we read,

> *"Wherefore (as the Holy Ghost saith, To day if ye will hear his voice, Harden not your hearts…)."*

Yet the quotation that follows comes from Psalm 95. David wrote it, but Hebrews says the Holy Ghost is the one speaking. When God moved in David to write those words, they were not the words of David, they were the words of God; this is inspiration.

That is why Jesus declared in Matthew 4:4,

> *"Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God."*

Our Lord did not say "every thought," but "every word." Inspiration reaches to the level of words, even to the smallest strokes of letters, as He also said in Matthew 5:18:

“Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled.”

God breathes out words, not simply concepts.
If the Bible were only partially inspired, or only in its “ideas,” then we could never be sure which parts were trustworthy and which parts were human opinion. But because inspiration extends to every word, we can open our Bibles with the confidence that we are hearing God’s own voice.

However, a problem arises among modern scholarship **after** this teaching of inspiration. A very common phrase you will find on almost any website of most major churches or seminaries, especially ones who do not hold to the King James Bible as the final authority but believe in the Word of God existing today in some vague form between all of the different versions of the Bible, is that they will make all of these amazing statements about the Bible, such as: it is inspired, inerrant, infallible, plenary, and many other lofty claims, followed by three words of tragedy: “in the originals.”

When they make this statement, what they are truly telling you is that only thousands of years ago did the Word of God exist in all of those amazing adjective forms that they previously described. If you were to ask them where the

Word of God is today, you would receive a wide array of answers, and yet there is one common thread in all of those answers: the Word of God does not exist now in that inerrant, infallible, plenary form that they claimed.

Thus, the prophecy of Amos is fulfilled,

Amos 8:11–12

> "Behold, the days come, saith the Lord GOD, that I will send a famine in the land, not a famine of bread, nor a thirst for water, but of hearing the words of the LORD: And they shall wander from sea to sea, and from the north even to the east, they shall run to and fro to seek the word of the LORD, and shall not find it."

In the world we live in today, according to that line of thinking, nobody can find the Word of God, because in order to find it you would have to build a time machine and travel back thousands of years ago to the original inspired copy of Scripture. As soon as that copy was destroyed, within 20, 30, 40, 50, or even 100 years, the Word of God ceased to exist in that perfect form that was described.

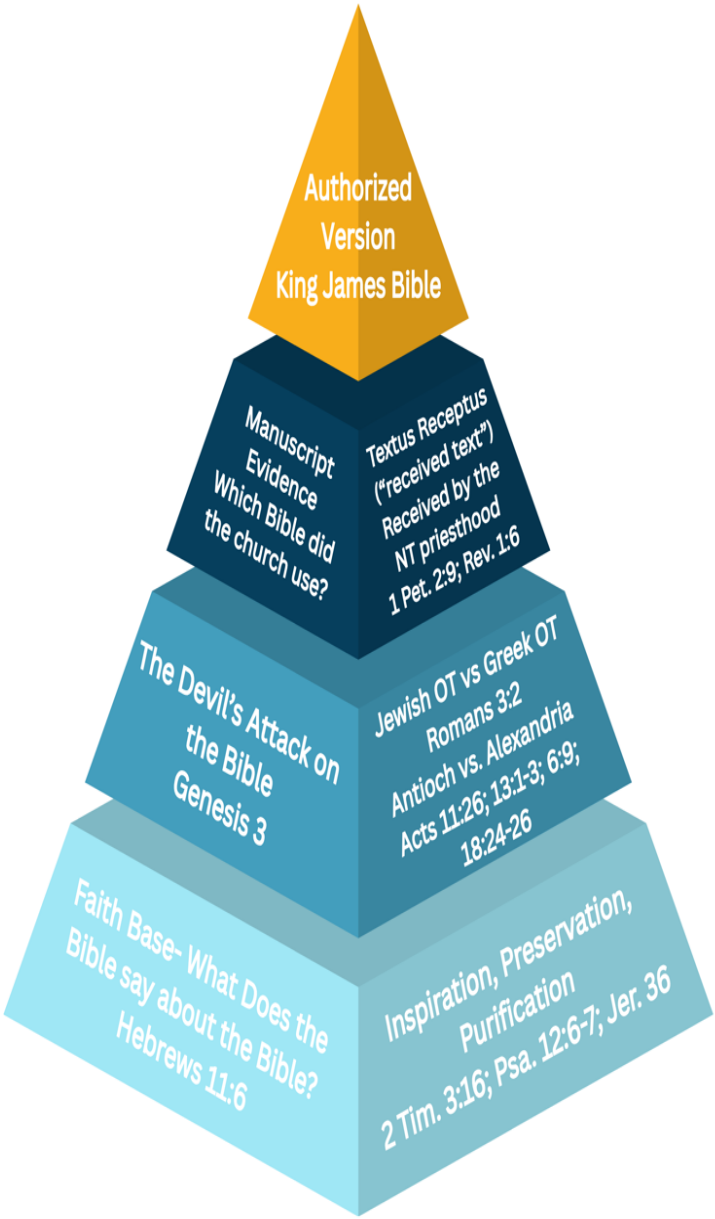
And so the question arises: What good then would inspiration be if it only existed in that form for those few years that the original copy lasted?

Wesley Huff the New Testament manuscript scholar once again said,[4]

> "Here's the question that modern translators want to get down to, and this is the question when I do textual research that I want to get down to: What did the original author say?"

However, the question we must answer throughout this book is: Is that a biblical view of the Word of God or is there more to the Bible than simply the inspiration and the original copy that lasted for only a few short years.

[4] "Part 1: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," *Cultish* (YouTube video), January 8, 2025, 56:00, posted by CultishTV, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yLGTS6Q82kE.


Authorized Version King James Bible
Manuscript Evidence Which Bible did the church use?
Textus Receptus ("received text") Received by the NT priesthood 1 Pet. 2:9; Rev. 1:6
The Devil's Attack on the Bible Genesis 3
Jewish OT vs Greek OT Romans 3:2 Antioch vs. Alexandria Acts 11:26; 13:1-3; 6:9; 18:24-26
Faith Base- What Does the Bible say about the Bible? Hebrews 11:6
Inspiration, Preservation, Purification 2 Tim. 3:16; Psa. 12:6-7; Jer. 36

Faith Based?

My position, to put it simply, is this: I believe that the perfect, inerrant, infallible, plenary Word of God exists in the world today, and you can find it in a book. You can find it, every jot and every tittle, exactly as God preserved it, as He promised to. And I arrived at this position from a faith-based view of the Word of God.

The position begins with the promises of the word of God, the principles taught in the word of God and then moves into the evidence from history. With a position that is founded in faith through the principles in the Bible, we can interpret this issue in history from God's perspective, not mankind's.

In Colossians we are told that as we received Christ Jesus the Lord, so we should walk in Him, rooted and established in the faith.

> **Colossians 2:6–7**
> *As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him: Rooted and built up in him, and stablished in the faith, as ye have been taught, abounding therein with thanksgiving.*

In Hebrews we are told that without faith it is impossible to please God.

> **Hebrews 11:6**
> *But without faith it is impossible to please him: for he that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him.*

From the very beginning of our Christian existence, from the very moment of regeneration, we were called to walk in faith and by faith.

So then where does that faith come from? The Bible tells us:

> **Romans 10:17**
> "So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God."

Everything that we do ought to come from a faith-based relationship with God that is established in the Word of God.

Most Christians would admit to believing that. However, when it comes to the most foundational issue—which is: Where is the Word of God today? Where can I go and read, in a book, that plenary, perfect, infallible, inspired,

inerrant Word of God that has been promised through Scripture?—there is much hesitation.

Think about it: I am placing my eternity in the hands of the contents of this book. This book is supposed to be a reflection of God Himself. We see in John chapter 1 that the Word is God:

> **John 1:1, 14**
> "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God… And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth."

Also in John's first epistle we see,

> **1 John 5:7**
> "For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one."

And in Psalm 138:2 we are told:

"…for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name."

How could God do this? Why would He do this, making His Word equal to Himself and even establishing His Word above His name? The answer is actually very simple: because our God is a perfect God, and when He speaks, He speaks perfectly. He does not take anything back, and there would be no reason He would separate Himself from what He says. He cannot say things that contradict Himself, and so He is inseparable from His Word, as established in the Word of God.

And so today, so that we can please our God by living in faith, and so that we can walk as He called us to in Colossians, “as ye have therefore received Christ Jesus the Lord, so walk ye in him”, and so that we can reverence the Word of God as we would God Himself, we must hold the same opinion of the Word of God that we hold of God: that it is perfect as He is perfect, that it is eternal as He is eternal, and so on.

Therefore, we will seek to establish a foundation from the Bible itself as to where we can find the Word of God today. Any man-made or scientific system of trying to establish where the Word of God is today will inevitably fall short, because it is not grounded in faith. Any view of the Word of God that is not grounded in faith is not spiritually understood and therefore will always fall short.

What we will find is that the Bible has much to say about itself, where we can find it, promises about the Word of God, and God's attachment of Himself to it through preservation and purification, so that we are not left guessing about where the Word of God is, or if it in fact exists today.

Shared Attributes	Written Word — Scripture (KJV)	Living Word — Jesus Christ (KJV)
Called "the Word of God"	1 Thes 2:13; Mk 7:13; Lk 8:21	Rev 19:13; Jn 1:1,14
Creator / Agent of creation	Ps 33:6,9; Heb 11:3	Jn 1:3; Col 1:16; Heb 1:2
Sustains / Upholds	Ps 119:89–91,116; Ps 147:15–18	Heb 1:3; Col 1:17
Living & powerful	Heb 4:12	Lk 4:32; Jn 6:63
Truth	Jn 17:17; Ps 119:160	Jn 14:6; Rev 3:14
Enduring	1 Pet 1:23,25; Ps 119:89	Mt 24:35; Heb 13:8
Light	Ps 119:105; Prov 6:23	Jn 8:12; Jn 12:46
Life-giving	Deut 8:3; 1 Pet 2:2; Jer 15:16	Jn 6:35,63; Jn 10:10
Saves / Brings new birth	Jas 1:18; 1 Pet 1:23; Rom 1:16	Mt 1:21; Jn 3:16–17; Acts 4:12
Judges / Standard of judgment	Heb 4:12; Jn 12:48	Jn 5:22,27; 2 Cor 5:10
Sanctifies / Cleanses	Jn 17:17; Eph 5:26	Eph 5:25–27; Heb 13:12
Pure / Without flaw	Ps 12:6; Prov 30:5; Ps 18:30	1 Pet 1:19; Heb 7:26
Heals	Ps 107:20	Mt 8:16–17; Lk 7:7; Jn 4:50
Sword	Eph 6:17; Heb 4:12	Rev 1:16; Rev 2:12; Rev 19:15
Produces faith / Faith's object	Rom 10:17; 1 Thes 2:13	Jn 20:31; Jn 3:16; Acts 20:21; Heb 12:2
Peace & Joy	Ps 119:165; Jer 15:16	Jn 14:27; Jn 15:11
Freedom / Liberty	Ps 119:45; Jas 1:25	Jn 8:31–32,36
Cleansing by the word	Ps 119:9; Eph 5:26	Jn 15:3
Central to "revelation"	2 Tim 3:16–17; Rom 15:4	Heb 1:1–2; Jn 1:18
Searches and Discerns hearts	Heb 4:12	Rev 2:23
Abides in believers	1 Jn 2:14; Col 3:16	Jn 15:4–5; Gal 2:20 (Christ living in me)
Gives hope/comfort	Rom 15:4; Ps 119:49–50	1 Tim 1:1; Col 1:27; Jn 14:18
Honored / Magnified	Ps 138:2	Jn 5:23
Tried / Proven	Ps 18:30; Prov 30:5	Isa 28:16; 1 Pet 2:6; Heb 4:15
Commands obedience	Jas 1:22; Ps 119:4	Jn 14:15; Lk 6:46
Blessing to doers	Jas 1:25; Ps 1:1–3	Lk 11:28; Mt 7:24–25
Spirit-empowered / Spirit-given	2 Pet 1:21; Eph 6:17	Lk 4:18; Acts 10:38; Jn 3:34
Fire	Jer 23:29	Lk 12:49; Rev 1:14; Rev 19:15

PRESERVATION: WHAT GOD PROMISED TO CONTINUE

At this point, most of modern scholarship ceases to understand the promises concerning the Word of God from the Bible itself. On almost any website you would find (whether from a Christian church, a non-denominational group, or any denomination really) that they believe in the inspiration of the Word of God as taught in the Scriptures, but they do not go so far as to believe in the preservation promises of the Word of God as the Bible discusses them.

Again, what a shame this is. The inspiration of the Bible, to put it simply, is of no use if it was only going to promise us a generation or less of the perfect, infallible, inerrant, plenary Word of God.

But good news for us: the Bible does promise us more than just the inspiration of the words of God.

The Promises of Preservation

Psalm 12:6–7

“The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep

them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."

Psalm 119:89

"For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven."

Psalm 119:152

"Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever."

Psalm 119:160

"Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever."

Isaiah 40:8

"The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever."

Isaiah 59:21

"As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the LORD; My spirit that is upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth, nor out of

the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the LORD, from henceforth and for ever."

Matthew 5:18

"For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled."

Luke 16:17

"And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass, than one tittle of the law to fail."

Matthew 24:35 (cf. Mark 13:31; Luke 21:33)

"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away."

John 10:35

"…the scripture cannot be broken;"

1 Peter 1:23–25

"Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever. For all flesh is as grass, and all the glory of man

as the flower of grass. The grass withereth, and the flower thereof falleth away: But the word of the Lord endureth for ever. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you."

All of these promises are clear: the Word of God, even down to the very jot and tittle, the smallest of strokes in Hebrew letters, would not pass away, but would be completely kept, perfect and sure, every single letter, every single word, forever.

Now, the hard part about these promises is not understanding them but believing them. The Bible is very clear in its teaching on the keeping of the Word of God. Again, it tells us not only that the ideas would be kept, or the teachings would be kept and preserved, but that the very words, down to the very letters and strokes of the pen, would be kept.

By faith, this is to be believed. If you are not somebody who is interested in grounding your beliefs about the Bible in faith, and you are only interested in the science of textual criticism and understanding things from man's perspective and in man's wisdom, then this book may not be of interest to you.

This book seeks to understand this subject from one foundation only, from faith in the promises about the word

of God, from the word of God itself. Not science, not the wisdom of man, not textual criticism, not anything other than the foundation of the Bible. That will be the foundation of this argument.

We will, however, get into the details of the manuscripts and the facts of history later on. But for now we must establish this: if we cannot, by faith, believe God's promises about preserving His Word and purifying his word, just as we do about inspiring His Word, then understanding those more technical issues is of no benefit.

Copies as Scripture

We find many different scripture passages that testify to the fact that not only the originals are seen as Scripture, but copies of the originals are also seen as Scripture in the Bible. This goes directly against the idea that the originals are to be emphasized, and that the originals are the only things that are inspired or the very Word of God.

Copies of Scripture are all over the Bible, elevated to the place of Scripture, nothing less.

Deuteronomy 17:18–19

"And it shall be, when he sitteth upon the throne of his kingdom, that he shall write him a copy of this law in a

book out of that which is before the priests the Levites: And it shall be with him, and he shall read therein all the days of his life: that he may learn to fear the LORD his God, to keep all the words of this law and these statutes, to do them:"

2 Kings 22:8, 11, 13

(v.8) "And Hilkiah the high priest said unto Shaphan the scribe, I have found the book of the law in the house of the LORD. And Hilkiah gave the book to Shaphan, and he read it."
(v.11) "And it came to pass, when the king had heard the words of the book of the law, that he rent his clothes."
(v.13) "Go ye, enquire of the LORD for me, and for the people, and for all Judah, concerning the words of this book that is found: for great is the wrath of the LORD that is kindled against us, because our fathers have not hearkened unto the words of this book, to do according unto all that which is written concerning us."

Ezra 7:14

"…according to the law of thy God which is in thine hand;"

Nehemiah 8:8

“So they read in the book in the law of God distinctly, and gave the sense, and caused them to understand the reading.”

Luke 4:17–21

“And there was delivered unto him the book of the prophet Esaias. And when he had opened the book, he found the place where it was written… And he began to say unto them, This day is this scripture fulfilled in your ears.”

Acts 8:28–35

“…and sitting in his chariot read Esaias the prophet. Then the Spirit said unto Philip, Go near, and join thyself to this chariot… The place of the scripture which he read was this, He was led as a sheep to the slaughter… Then Philip opened his mouth, and began at the same scripture, and preached unto him Jesus.”

Acts 17:11

“These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so.”

2 Timothy 3:15–16

“And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus. All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness:”

The testimony is undeniable: the Bible calls *copies* “Scripture.” It never restricts inspiration and authority to the vanished “original autographs.” God promised to preserve His Word forever, and He did so in the copies His people held, read, preached, and believed.

PURIFICATION: HOW GOD ACTIVELY REFINES THE BIBLE

Now, in this subject of the Word of God and what the Bible says about the keeping of the Word of God and our grounding faith on the subject, we take a turn that most others never dare. The majority of Christianity today does not take the promises about the Bible past the point of inspiration into preservation. Even less take it past the promises of preservation into purification.

The irony of this is that the Bible speaks explicitly about the purification of the Word of God, just as it does about the preceding promises of inspiration and preservation.

Again, we look at **Psalm 12:6–7**:

> "The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."

God explicitly promises in these verses that He is going to **purify** His Word, not just keep it, not just write it in an original form and then let it go to the wayside in a short amount of time and be gone forever, but He tells us that

He is going to preserve it and, in fact, even purify it "seven times".

If you do a study of the number seven in the Bible, you will find that it represents perfection or completeness. And so, God is going to purify it until its final form, where it is perfect, complete, and final, needing no more purification.

SIDENOTE:

This process of purification can also be traced in the history of the English Bible. God did not give us the King James Bible all at once; rather, He refined His Word step by step through earlier English translations until it reached its final, purified form in 1611. Many have noticed how this storyline echoes the "seven times" purification in Psalm 12. Looking back, you can see seven big steps that lead up to the King James:

1. **Wycliffe (1382)** — first complete English Bible, translated from the Old Latin.[5]

[5] Gail Riplinger, *In Awe of Thy Word* (Ararat, VA: AV Publications, 2003), 788–796. Riplinger explains that the myth of Wycliffe's Bible being taken from Jerome's Latin Vulgate arose from the **1850 Forshall–Madden edition**, which placed the misleading phrase *"made from the Latin Vulgate"* on its title page . She contrasts this with a **1380 Bible title page**, preserved in Foxe's *Acts and Monuments*, which reads: *"translated into English from the vulgar Latin, by John Wycliffe,*

2. **Tyndale (1525)** — first English from Hebrew and Greek; laid the groundwork.
3. **Coverdale (1535)** — first complete printed English Bible, building on Tyndale.
4. **Matthew's (1537)** — a blend of Tyndale and Coverdale (John Rogers).
5. **Great Bible (1539)** — first "authorized" English Bible, placed in churches.
6. **Bishops' (1568)** — a Church of England revision.
7. **Geneva (1560)** — the people's Bible, loved by the Puritans, loaded with notes.

Finally, in 1611 the King James Bible brought together and refined all of these, serving as the purified and preserved Word of God in English, just as Psalm 12 promises. It was the 8th English translation, fully purified (8 in the Bible is representative of "new beginnings". The KJV certainly was exactly that as it ushered in the greatest worldwide missions revival this world has seen).

We see in **Proverbs 30:5–6**:

D.D. Rector of Lutterworth 1380" (Foxe, vol. 3, p. 64 n. 2), showing it was from the **Old Latin (vulgar Latin)**, not Jerome's Vulgate .

> “Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar.”

He is commanding that we not add to His words, but He is telling us that His Word is pure (it has been purified).

We also see in **Psalm 18:30**:

> “As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him.”

The Word of the LORD is tried. There are different ways you could take this, but again, in the context of seeing it as a purified, tried Book, we can see the same premise being taught here.

Case Study: Showing Purification in Action

Jeremiah 36:27–28, 32

> “Then the word of the LORD came to Jeremiah, after that the king had burned the roll, and the words which Baruch wrote at the mouth of Jeremiah, saying,

> Take thee again another roll, and write in it all the former words that were in the first roll, which Jehoiakim the king of Judah hath burned.
> Then took Jeremiah another roll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah; who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: **and there were added besides unto them many like words.**"

Lessons from Jeremiah

In this peculiar story in the book of Jeremiah, we learn many things.

We learn that those who emphasize the originals over everything else, and those who say the only goal is to recover the original words of the original author written down thousands of years ago, are not standing on a biblical premise but a man-made construct.

When you put this story together with the other verses in the Bible promising the purification of the Word of God, you find that God is not in the business of emphasizing the "originals."

In fact, you could draw a correlation between man's obsession with the originals and the Israelites' obsession

with artifacts: the sword that David killed Goliath with, the armor of Goliath, or the brazen serpent that Moses erected in the wilderness. We tend to cling to artifacts, but God does not emphasize the originals.

In this story, God did something very peculiar. He gave Jeremiah His Word and had Baruch write it down. Then He allowed that original roll to be cut up and burned, completely destroyed. So now the original copy was gone. That original, inerrant, plenary, inspired copy was gone.

But God had promised to preserve His Word. And so He told Jeremiah to write another roll with all the former words in it. Preservation in action.

Yet something very interesting also happened. God added to that second copy *"many like words."*

What This Shows

This means that if modern scholars had their wish, and they had the "original copy" of Jeremiah, they would in fact be missing out on the complete revelation of God, because it was the second, purified copy that had the fullness of His words.

Ask yourself, why would God allow this to happen? Could he not have prevented the destruction of the coveted

“original” copy? Could he not have just had it rewritten exactly as it was in the “original”? Why not say the “added” words in the original copy? God is all knowing, all powerful, perfect, etc.. Why would he add to what he said the first time?

The answer is that God was showing us something important: that the original copy is not to be exalted or worshipped. Instead, He demonstrates His promise of purification. His Word would be purified through time under His guiding hand.

He gave us a case study of inspiration, preservation, and purification.

To Review:

1. **The coveted “Original” Written**.

“Then Jeremiah called Baruch the son of Neriah: and Baruch wrote from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the LORD, which he had spoken unto him, upon a roll of a book.” (Jer. 36:4)

2. **The coveted “Original” Destroyed**

“And it came to pass, that when Jehudi had read three or four leaves, he cut it with the penknife, and cast it into the

fire… until all the roll was consumed in the fire that was on the hearth." (Jer. 36:23)

3. **The Second Roll Written (preserved copy)**

"Take thee again another roll, and write in it all the former words that were in the first roll, which Jehoiakim the king of Judah hath burned." (Jer. 36:28)

4. **Additional Words Added (purified/preserved copy)**

"Then took Jeremiah another roll… who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: ***and there were added besides unto them many like words.*** (Jer. 36:32)

This shows God's work of ***purification****. The second roll was not less than the first, but greater, it contained the complete revelation God wanted preserved.*

"Double Inspiration"?

Those who poke fun at the idea of the King James Bible often say its defenders believe in "double inspiration." Nothing could be further from the truth.

Inspiration is, by definition, the initial act of God breathing out His Word. That happened once, in the originals.

But what many critics miss are the principles of **preservation** and especially **purification** as they are taught in the Bible.

God can and does providentially purify His Word, just as He did here in Jeremiah, and just as He did through history in the pure line of manuscripts and Bibles, as opposed to the corrupt line of manuscripts and Bibles.

This is not “double inspiration.” It is purification. It is biblical. And it is faith-based.

FAITH BASED VIEW OF SCRIPTURE

By Faith we Believe God's Promise that He Inspired his word

2 Timothy 3:16- All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness:
2 Peter 1:21- For the prophecy came not in old time by the will of man: but holy men of God spake as they were moved by the Holy Ghost.
Acts 1:16- Men and brethren, this scripture must needs have been fulfilled, which the Holy Ghost by the mouth of David spake before concerning Judas, which was guide to them that took Jesus.
Acts 28:25- And when they agreed not among themselves, they departed, after that Paul had spoken one word, Well spake the Holy Ghost by Esaias the prophet unto our fathers,
Acts 3:18- But those things, which God before had shewed by the mouth of all his prophets, that Christ should suffer, he hath so fulfilled.
Mark 12:36- For David himself said by the Holy Ghost, The LORD said to my Lord, Sit thou on my right hand, till I make thine enemies thy footstool.

By Faith we Believe God's Promise to Preserve His inspired word

Matthew 24:35- Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away.
1 Peter 1:23- Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever.
Psalm 12:6-7- The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.
Psalm 111:7-8- The works of his hands are verity and judgment; all his commandments are sure. They stand fast for ever and ever, and are done in truth and uprightness.
Psalm 117:2- For his merciful kindness is great toward us: and the truth of the LORD endureth for ever. Praise ye the LORD.
Psalm 119:152, 160- Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded them for ever. Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever.

By Faith we Believe God's Promise to Purify His word

Psalm 12:6-7- The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth, purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever.
Jeremiah 36- ..... "Then took Jeremiah another roll, and gave it to Baruch the scribe, the son of Neriah; who wrote therein from the mouth of Jeremiah all the words of the book which Jehoiakim king of Judah had burned in the fire: and there were added besides unto them many like words."
Psalm 66:10- For thou, O God, hast proved us: thou hast tried us, as silver is tried.
Psalm 18:30- As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all those that trust in him.
2 Samuel 22:31- As for God, his way is perfect; the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler to all them that trust in him.
Proverbs 30:5- Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him.

By Faith we Believe God is Inseparable from His word

Psalm 138:2- I will worship toward thy holy temple, and praise thy name for thy lovingkindness and for thy truth: for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name.
Titus 1:2- In hope of eternal life, which God, that cannot lie, promised before the world began;
Numbers 23:19- God is not a man, that he should lie; neither the son of man, that he should repent: hath he said, and shall he not do it? or hath he spoken, and shall he not make it good?
1 Samuel 15:29- And also the Strength of Israel will not lie nor repent: for he is not a man, that he should repent.
John 1:1,14- In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God. And the Word was made flesh, and dwelt among us, (and we beheld his glory, the glory as of the only begotten of the Father,) full of grace and truth.

All different versions of the Bible say different things. They all can't be 100% correct because they say different things, and in many places opposite things; that would be impossible. Would you be confident placing your eternity in the hands of a book you can only trust 90% of the time, or even 99% of the time? You don't have to settle for less than 100% certainty. Because of the promises of God we have concerning his word, you can know which one to trust 100% of the time!

While God is committed to purifying His words, the devil is committed to corrupting them. From Genesis onward.

I put this section underneath the faith-based view of the Word of God because I believe that not understanding this issue in the Bible will ultimately be a detriment to anybody who endeavors to study the Word of God in its transmission through time, and where it exists today. To not understand the spiritual warfare on the Word of God from the Bible itself will leave you lacking in your ability to discern what the Word of God is, where it is, where the work of God is throughout history, and where the work of the devil is.

Wesley Huff again in this same interview in 2025 said,[6]

> "There aren't people behind the scenes who are mischievously trying to take out verses of our Bible to hide things or create contradictions. If that were true, then if you look at the so-called missing verses, they're doing a really bad job of it. They're basically taking out inconsequential verses while

[6] "Part 1: Answering King James Only w/ Wes Huff," *Cultish* (YouTube video), January 8, 2025, 56:00, posted by Cultish TV, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yLGTS6Q82kE.

> leaving in some pretty big verses that have major doctrinal effects. So if this is a nefarious conspiracy to remove doctrines or ideas from Scripture, whoever is taking these verses out is doing a pretty bad job of it."

This statement again lacks a biblically, spiritual, faith-based understanding on this subject. Scholars who seek to understand this issue only from the carnal viewpoint of man, science, philosophy, textual criticism and not through the lens of the word of God, will be left in the dark.

By faith, we believe that the Bible teaches that there is a pointed and concerted effort from the forces of spiritual wickedness to corrupt the Word of God.

God's Repeated Warnings

God, from the very beginning of His Word, warns mankind not to add to His Word or take away from His Word. In the very middle of His Word, in the book of Proverbs, He gives the same warning (Prov. 30:5-6). At the very end, in the book of Revelation, He gives it again (Rev. 22:18-19). All throughout the Bible, God places warnings against adding to or taking away from His words.

False Letters in the Early Church

Even in the days of the apostles, the integrity of God's Word was under attack. Paul had to warn believers about false letters that were being circulated in his name. In 2 Thessalonians 2:2, he cautions the church not to be "shaken in mind" or deceived by "spirit, nor by word, nor by **letter as from us**." Later, in 2 Thessalonians 3:17, he made it a point to identify his own hand in writing, so that the churches could recognize the true Word from counterfeit documents. These warnings show that even while the New Testament was being penned and circulated, Satan was already working to undermine its authority by slipping in corrupted "copies".

The Devil's First Appearance

The very first time that the devil shows up in the Bible is in Genesis 3, and right from the jump, he is attacking the foundation of our faith; the word of God.

1. **He questions the Word of God.**

"Yea, hath God said…?" (Genesis 3:1)

I've spent a significant amount of time in colleges, seminaries, and listening to various opinions on the Bible itself, manuscript evidence, and textual criticism. And I found that this is the core question of textual criticism: *"Yea, hath God said?"*

There's just enough doubt inserted as to what was originally said, if it exists today, and where it is found in the manuscripts, that it creates confusion in the mind of the reader. It causes them to doubt the authenticity of the Bible, or at least specific passages. This is exactly what it did in the mind of Eve.

2. **He Contradicts the Word of God.**

"…Yea, hath God said, Ye shall not eat of every tree of the garden?" (Genesis 3:1)

That twist was the point. God had not said they were forbidden to eat of every tree. Eve initially corrected the claim, saying that only one tree was off-limits. But the seed of doubt and contradiction had already been planted.

3. **He changes the Word of God.**

"Ye shall not surely die." (Genesis 3:4)

God had been perfectly clear that in the day they ate of the tree, they would die. Satan contradicted this directly, convincing Eve that God was withholding something from her.

Eve's Addition

Notice also that Eve, in her response, added to God's Word:

"…neither shall ye touch it, lest ye die." (Genesis 3:3)

God never said they could not *touch* it. But with the devil questioning, contradicting, and changing God's Word, Eve herself misquoted Him, adding something He never commanded.

The Pattern

So in just a few verses we see the entire satanic strategy:

- Question the Word of God.
- Contradict the Word of God.
- Change the Word of God.

This pattern has never stopped. It is the same today as it was then.

The devil convinced Eve that God was holding out on her, hiding knowledge from her, by questioning His Word, contradicting it, and then changing it. Through this, the human race fell from perfection and intimate fellowship with Christ in the garden into the chaos, sin, and death we now see. And all it took was an attack on the Word of God.

The Continuing Attack

I submit to you that the devil has not stopped his attack on the Word of God from that very day. From the very beginning of Scripture's writing, there have been attacks on the Word of God. To deny this is to miss one of the central themes of the Bible: the devil is in the business of corrupting what God has spoken. Scholars may say, "There is nobody out there trying to corrupt your Bible or your manuscripts." But the Bible itself tells us otherwise. To not believe that the devil is trying to change what God said, contradict what God said, or question what God said in order to cause us to sin or to waver from the faith, is to reject the testimony of Scripture. By faith, we believe that there is a pointed attack on the Word of God today by the devil and his angels.

NOTE:

Many claim that this issue of Bible versions is overblown and that the versions all tend to say the same things, teach the same things, and that there are not MAJOR differences. The irony of this is that we find not "small changes" but outright opposite teachings within the **same chapter** where God shows us Satan's attack method on the word of God.

Ex. Genesis 3:16

In the King James Bible, God's judgment upon the woman is clear:

> *"Unto the woman he said, I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children;* ***and thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee.*** (Gen. 3:16, KJV)

The KJV renders this as the wife's desire being *toward* her husband, fitting the natural, God-ordained order of marriage. The consequence of the Fall is pain in childbearing and a struggle of submission, but the structure is consistent: her desire is *to her husband,* and he shall rule over her.

Now compare the English Standard Version (ESV):

> *"To the woman he said, 'I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children.* ***Your desire shall be contrary to your husband, but he shall rule over you.*** (Gen. 3:16, ESV)

Notice the difference: instead of being *to her husband,* the woman's desire is rendered as *contrary to her husband.* That is not a minor adjustment of language, it is the exact opposite. In one, the wife's desire is directed *toward* her husband. In the other, her desire is set *against* him.

TWO LINES OF BIBLES: ANTIOCH VS. ALEXANDRIA

When you trace the history of the Bible, it becomes clear that there has always been a battle over the text. This battle is not new. From the Garden of Eden, the very first recorded words of the serpent were: *"Yea, hath God said?"* (Gen. 3:1). Satan's strategy has not changed in six thousand years. The question before us is not whether there are different manuscripts, languages, or translations. The real question is: **Why are there conflicting lines of manuscripts? Why do some say one thing and other lines from other areas say other things? Can we ground our understanding of which lines we should trust in the word of God (faith based)? If we can, then we can see where God is purifying his word vs. where Satan is corrupting his word.**

The evidence of Scripture and history says yes. When you study the story of the transmission of the Bible, it comes down to a tale of two cities: **Antioch** and **Alexandria**. One city represents missions, evangelism, and doctrinal purity. The other represents philosophy, corruption, and compromise. This is not just a matter of geography, it is a

matter of spiritual lineage and biblical principles (faith based). The manuscripts that come from these places bear the fruit of the soil in which they grew.

Antioch: The Line of Preservation

The Bible itself highlights Antioch as a city of great spiritual importance.

- **Acts 11:26** tells us, *"the disciples were called Christians first in Antioch."* The very name "Christian" was born there, not in Jerusalem, Rome, or Alexandria.

- In **Acts 13:1–3**, Antioch becomes the **missions hub** of the New Testament. It was from Antioch that Paul and Barnabas were sent out by the Holy Ghost on the first missionary journey. This city was the launching pad of gospel expansion. The light of world evangelism began to blaze from Antioch.

It is no coincidence that the **text of Scripture preserved and used by the churches** came from this same region. Antioch represents the spirit of obedience to the Word of God. It represents evangelism, church planting, doctrinal faithfulness, and biblical literalism. Historically, the manuscripts associated with Antioch became the **Byzantine Text**, later known as the **Textus Receptus**.

Over 5,200 Greek manuscripts (more than 95% of the evidence) agree with this line of text .

These were the Scriptures preached in the Greek-speaking churches. They were the basis of the Old Latin Bible (Itala, 2nd century) and the Syriac Peshitta (2nd century). Early church fathers quoted them thousands of times. Polycarp, a direct disciple of the apostle John, quoted readings found in the Textus Receptus. His disciple, Irenaeus (130–200 A.D.), did the same. Both men quoted controversial passages such as **1 John 5:7** and **Mark 16:9–20**, which modern critical texts leave out. This proves that these verses are not "later additions," but part of the Bible known and received in the earliest centuries.

Dean John Burgon, who collated these manuscripts in the 1800s, wrote in his book *Revision Revised*:[7]

> *"Lectionaries abound, which establish the Text which has been publicly read in the churches of the East, from at least A.D. 400 until the time of the invention of printing."*

[7] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 37.

He also said in the same book,[8]

> "…the Text which, by the good Providence of GOD, was universally employed throughout Europe for the first 300 years after the invention of printing… being practically identical with the Text which … was in popular use at the end of three centuries from the date of the sacred autographs themselves: in other words, being more than 1500 years old."

The Textus Receptus is the text that the body of Christ used, copied, and believed through the centuries. That is why it is called the "Received Text", because the churches received it as the Word of God.

Alexandria: The Line of Corruption

The Law of First Mention: Egypt as Bondage and Compromise

The law of first mention is a Bible study principle: the first time a subject shows up in Scripture, it often sets the tone for how it's treated later. Egypt's first appearance is **Genesis 12:10**. Abraham "went down into Egypt" during a famine, and there he slipped into fear and half-truths about

[8] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 401.

Sarah. That opening scene isn't an accident; it frames Egypt as a place where God's people are tempted to compromise.

The thread keeps running through the Bible:

- **Exodus 12–14** — Israel's greatest rescue is *out of* Egypt: out of slavery, idolatry, and paganism.
- **Exodus 12:12** — The plagues are God's judgment on Egypt's gods.
- **Isaiah 31:1; Jeremiah 42:19** — The prophets warn, again and again: don't go back to Egypt for help.

Put simply, the Bible does not paint Egypt in a positive light. It stands as a symbol of danger, compromise, and doctrinal corruption.

If Antioch is the city of light, Alexandria is the city of shadows. In the Bible, Egypt is never a place of spiritual blessing.

- God says in **Exodus 20:2**: *"I am the LORD thy God, which have brought thee out of the land of Egypt, out of the house of bondage."* Egypt is bondage.

- **Isaiah 30:1–2** warns God's people not to go down to Egypt for help, because it represents dependence on the world instead of on God.
- **Revelation 11:8** calls Jerusalem, in its apostasy, "spiritually… Egypt." Egypt is a symbol of corruption, apostasy, and worldliness.

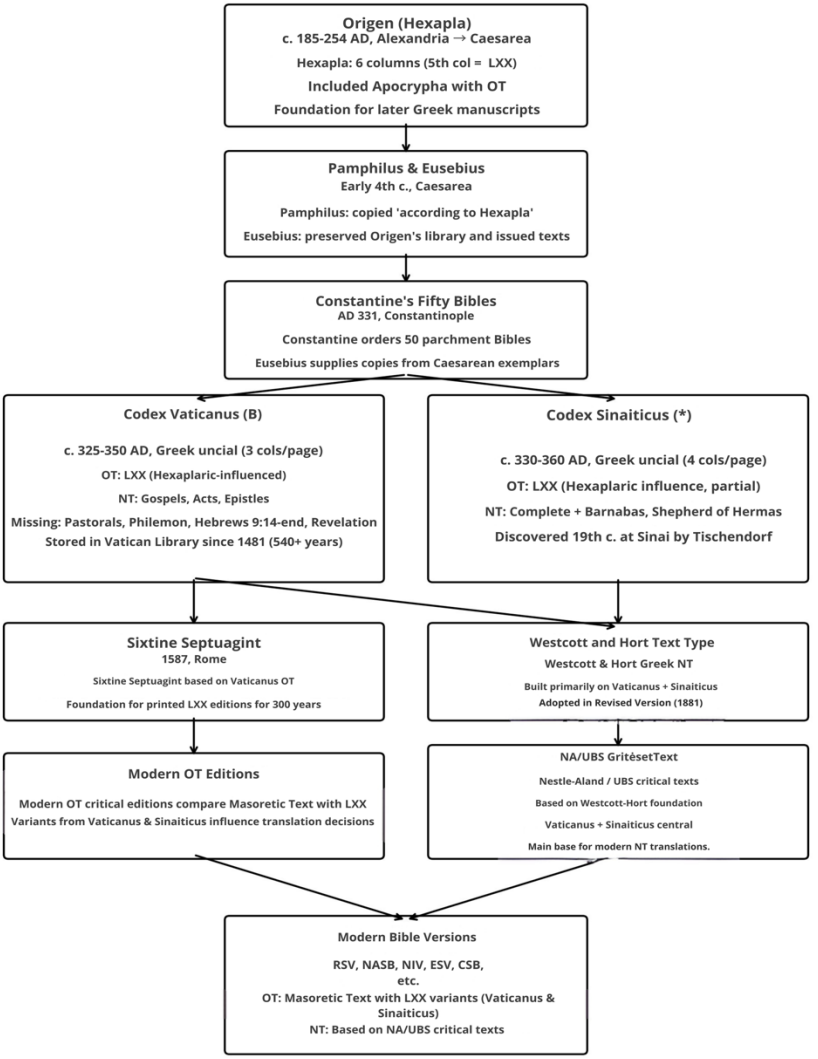
So, it is no surprise that when we study the history of Bible manuscripts, those that come out of Alexandria are marked by doctrinal corruption.

The book of Acts gives us hints of this:

- **Acts 6:9** records that some of the false witnesses who disputed with Stephen came from the "synagogue of the Libertines, and Cyrenians, and Alexandrians." The opposition to God's preacher came out of Alexandria.
- **Acts 18:24–26** tells us of Apollos, an eloquent preacher from Alexandria, who knew the Scriptures but had doctrinal deficiencies. He needed Aquila and Priscilla to "expound unto him the way of God more perfectly." Again, the Bible subtly points out that Alexandria produced men eloquent in speech, but tied to false doctrine, from Alexandria, Egypt.

The most famous name tied to Alexandria is **Origen (184–254 A.D.)**.

Origen → Codex Vaticanus & Sinaiticus → Modern Versions



Flowchart shows Origen's Hexapla → Constantine's Fifty Bibles → Codex Vaticanus & Sinaiticus → Sixtine LXX (OT) & Westcott-Hort (NT) → NA/UBS → Modern Versions.

Codex Vaticanus stored in Vatican Library since 1481 (540+ years).

KEY: The main manuscripts that are used in producing modern bibles can be directly traced back to Alexandria, Egypt and the work of Origen.[9] [10] [11] [12] [13]

[9] Anneli Aejmelaeus, "New Perspectives on the Textual Character of Codex Vaticanus," Svensk Exegetisk Årsbok 85 (2020): 3–17.

[10] Eusebius of Caesarea, Life of Constantine, trans. Averil Cameron and Stuart G. Hall (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1999), 166–69 (IV.36–37).

[11] T. C. Skeat, "The Codex Sinaiticus, the Codex Vaticanus and Constantine," Journal of Theological Studies, n.s., 50, no. 2 (1999): 583–625.

[12] Kristin De Troyer, "The Septuagint," in The New Cambridge History of the Bible, vol. 1, From the Beginnings to 600, ed. James Carleton Paget and Joachim Schaper (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013), 267–88.

[13] Bruce M. Metzger and Bart D. Ehrman, The Text of the New Testament, 4th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2005), 174–82, 305–13 (Westcott–Hort's privileging of B/א and the downstream influence on NA/UBS).

Origen was heretical. He denied the literal interpretation of Scripture[14], taught the pre-existence of souls[15], flirted with universal salvation[16], and mutilated the text of Scripture.

Phillip Schaff (**Professor of Church History** at Mercersburg & Union Seminary) said this of Origen,[17]

> "The predilection of Origen for Plato misled him into many grand and fascinating errors."

He was more of a philosopher and heretic than he was a Bible believer.

Benjamin Wilkinson summed up the beliefs of Origen well,[18]

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[14] Origen, *On First Principles* IV.1.16, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 4, trans. Frederick Crombie (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1869; repr., Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1980), 365.

[15] Origen, *On First Principles* II.9.1, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 4, 294.

[16] Origen, *On First Principles* I.6.3 and III.6.3, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 4, 259–260, 341.

[17] Philip Schaff, *History of the Christian Church*, Vol. II: *Ante-Nicene Christianity. A.D. 100–325* (New York: Charles Scribner's Sons, 1910), p. 791.

[18] Benjamin G. Wilkinson, Our Authorized Bible Vindicated (Washington, DC: n.p., 1930), 14.

> "He taught that the soul existed from eternity before it inhabited the body, and that after death, it migrated to a higher or a lower form of life according to the deeds done in the body; and finally all would return to the state of pure intelligence, only to begin again the same cycle as before. He believed that the devils would be saved, and that the stars and planets had souls, and were, like men, on trial to learn perfection. In fact, he turned the whole law and Gospel into an allegory."

His "great" work, the **Hexapla**, placed the Apocrypha alongside the inspired books and mingled together Greek translations in a way that caused great confusion. From this poisoned spring came much of what later influenced Jerome's Vulgate[19], the Vatican manuscript tradition, and ultimately the modern critical text.

The Alexandrian manuscripts themselves bear this corruption:

- **Codex Vaticanus (B)** omits entire books (Revelation, the Pastoral Epistles, etc.).

[19] Henry Barclay Swete, *An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 69–72.

- **Codex Sinaiticus (א)**, discovered in a wastebasket at St. Catherine's monastery, contains thousands of corrections by multiple hands.
- **Codex Alexandrinus (A)**, a later manuscript, mixes text types and is riddled with inconsistencies.

These manuscripts form less than **2%** of the evidence , yet they are exalted by modern critics as "older and better." The truth is, they are not in fact older and the few that are older are so only because they were rejected and unused by the churches. Like an unused tool left to rust in a closet, they survived because they were never trusted or worn out in preaching, copying, and evangelism.

Tale of Two Cities

When you put the pieces together, the contrast could not be clearer:

- Antioch is where believers were first called Christians. Alexandria is where false doctrine thrived.
- Antioch was the hub of missions. Alexandria was the center of philosophy.
- Antioch gave us the Textus Receptus and the Bibles of the Reformation. Alexandria gave us Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and the critical text that underlies modern versions.

- Antioch's line has borne the fruit of revival, missions, and doctrinal clarity. Alexandria's line has borne the fruit of skepticism, confusion, and doctrinal erosion.

Jesus said: *"Ye shall know them by their fruits"* (Matt. 7:16). Look at the fruits. The Reformation, the great awakenings, the missionary movements, all came from the Antiochian line of Bibles. In contrast, the line of Alexandria produced a stream of corrupted manuscripts, the rationalism of the Enlightenment, the skepticism of higher criticism, and a flood of modern versions that contradict one another and erode doctrines such as the deity of Christ, the virgin birth, the blood atonement, and the Trinity.

This is why the issue of "two lines of Bibles" is not about academic trivialities. It is a spiritual battlefield. The Word of God has always had enemies. But praise God, He has always preserved His Word for His people.

CHART KEY	
GREEN- KING JAMES BIBLE MANUSCRIPTS	RED- ALL MODERN BIBLE MANUSCRIPTS

Age Chart for Manuscripts

Old Testament Manuscripts		
Masoretic Text	Isaiah Scroll B (1QIsab)	175-100 BC
	The Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsaa)	175-100 BC
W&H Text Type (Septuagint or LXX)	Septuagint	Claims to be dated 200-250 BC
	Ryland Manuscript (fragment of Deuteronomy)	150 BC
	Origen's Hexapla	200 AD
New Testament Manuscripts		
Textus Receptus (Byzantian/Antiochan Text)	Peshitta Syriac	100-150 AD
	P66	100-200 AD
	P45	150-200 AD
	Church Father Quotes (2,630x)	69-400 AD
W&H Text Type (Alexandrian Texts)	Codex Vaticanus (B)	350-375 AD
	Codex Sinaiticus (א (Aleph))	300-400 AD
	Codex Alexandrinus (A)	400-500 AD

OLD TESTAMENT MANUSCRIPTS

Septuagint (Origens Hexapla)

- Also known as the Greek LXX

250-300 AD

Septuagint (Origens Hexapla)



- The actual existence of this MSS (manuscript) is highly debated. The only historical record of it ever existing comes from a "Letter from Aristeas" where Aristeas writes to his brother Philocrates about how the Pharaoh of Egypt at the time, Ptolomy Philadelphia, was trying to get a Greek translation of the OT Hebrew scriptures for there library. The story states that 72 Jewish elders (six from each of the twelve tribes) were hired for the job to go to Alexandria, Egypt to translate this great work. They supposedly translated it all in 72 days and gave it to the Pharaoh. It became known as the Septuagint because of the 72 translators who created the translation (inaccurately so, since Septuagint means "70" and there were 72 translators who took 72 days).
- The OT of new versions of the Bible are actually translated from a document known as Origen's Hexapla in his 5th column (Hexpla=5 columns). He poorly tried to translate the Hebrew OT all on his own! He was from the philosophical, bible rejecting, heretical college at Alexandria, Egypt. All modern bible versions OT are based on his translation of the OT into Greek
- Who was Origen?
  Believed Genesis 1-3 was not literal
  Believed in the allegorical interpretation method
  Believed Jesus was a created sub-god, not God
  Believed the Holy Spirit was a created being
  Believed in Salvation by works, not grace
  Believed in baptismal regeneration and sprinkling of babies
  Believed that Jesus' death was a ransom paid to Satan
  Believed in "purgatory" and not in a literal Hell
  Believed in universal salvation for all mankind
  Believed that Satan would be saved one day
  Believed that there is no bodily resurrection, but spiritual only
  Believed that there is no millennial kingdom of Jesus Christ
- These manuscripts contained the Apocrypha mixed in amongst the canonical books (inspired/preserved books) (Luke 24:27,44)
- Ultimately used by Westcott & Hort, two Bible rejecting, spiritualistic, heretics,to create the first Bible revision in 1885(274 years after the KJV) the English Revised Version
- Subsequently used to translate all new versions of the Bible since 1885

Massoretic Text

- The entirely Hebrew OT kept by the conservative Jewish group, the Masoretes
- The keeping of the scriptures, specifically as it pertains to the OT, was committed to the Jews: specifically to the Levites, priests, scribes, and the Jews as whole (Rom 3:2; Deut. 17:18; 31:24-26; Neh. 8:7-8; Deut. 4:1-2)

175 BC
Isaiah A (Dead Sea Scrolls)



100 BC
Isaiah B (Dead Sea Scrolls)



- Some rules they followed when copying the OT

  A roll must be written on the skins of a clean animal
  It must be prepared for use by a Jew
  It must be fastened together with strings from a clean animal
  Every skin must contain ascertain number of columns and they must be equal throughout the entire codex (MSS document)
  The length of every column must be 48 and 60 lines long
  The length of each line must be exactly 30 letters
  The whole copy must be lined
  The ink must be black prepared according to a particular recipe (non metallic)
  An authorized copy must be the exemplar (one being copied from)
  No word, not even a letter, can be written from memory
  Between every letter there must be the space of a hair or thread
  Between every new section there must be the space of 9 letters
  Between every book there must be 3 lines
  The 5th book of Moses (Deuteronomy) must end exactly with a line
  The copyist must sit in full Jewish dress
  The copyist must have just washed his whole entire body
  The copyist must write the name of God with a pen newly dipped in ink. He must again wash his whole body before writing the name of the Lord. And should a king address him while he is writing that name, he must ignore the king
- Used to translate the KJV in 1611

NEW TESTAMENT MANUSCRIPTS

Alexandrian Texts

- Also known as "Western Texts"
- The 3 Main MSS in use by scholars for translating new versions of the Bible are: Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus. Vaticanus is the most heavily relied on MSS

300-375 AD
Vaticanus



-Leaves out over 1,000 sentences
-Adds over 500 words
-Changed approximately 2,000 words
-In 17,000 places it differs from Sinaiticus
-It leaves out books of the NT and adds in books that are not found in the Bible

300-400 AD
Sinaiticus



-Found at the base of Mt. Sanai in Egypt in a kindling bin in a monastery
-Leaves out 4,000 words from the gospels alone
-Adds over 1,000 words
-Changes the reading of the text in 1,500 other places

400-500 AD
Alexandrinus



-Created in Alexandria Egypt at the school there
-Created in an environment of textual criticism and heresy
-Does not differ greatly from the other two main MSS and for that reason is used less for translating than the other two

- All are traced back to Alexandria, Egypt. This was a place of heresy and all bad things in the Bible. Also a picture of the world in the Bible. (Gen. 12:10; 13:10; Rev. 11:8)
- They are also a part of what is called the "Minority Text". This is because they account for only 45/5,255 extant (in existence) MSS
- Ultimately used by Westcott & Hort, two Bible rejecting, spiritualistic, heretics,to create the first Bible revision in 1885(274 years after the KJV) the English Revised Version
- Subsequently used to translate all new versions of the Bible since 1885

Antiochan Texts

- Also known as Byzantinian, Eastern, and Syrian texts
- Come from Antioch, Syria where they were first called Christians (Acts 11:26)
- MSS from this line date back as far as 100 AD

100-150 AD
Peshitta Syriac



100-200 AD
Papyrus #66



68-500 AD
2,680 Quotes from church fathers



- These texts are known as the Textus Receptus "Received Text". They got their name due to the fact that Christians as a whole, through the aid of the Holy Ghost, accepted these MSS as scripture. The NT scripture is determined by the NT priesthood just as the OT was through OT priesthood (Rev.1:6; 20:6; 1Pet. 2:9)
- They are also a part of what is called the "Majority Text". This is because they account for a staggering 5,210/5,255 extant MSS
- Antioch was also the center for missions work in the early church (Acts 13:1-3)
- Used to translate the KJV in 1611
- REFER TO MSS COPYING CHART FOR MORE DETAILS ON HOW THE TWO MSS FAMILIES WERE PASSED/COPIED

A. “TO THE JEW WERE COMMITTED THE ORACLES”

The starting point for any honest study of the Old Testament text must be God’s own testimony of who was given its custody. We are not left to guesswork or merely to the shifting opinions of textual critics. Scripture itself tells us plainly:

“What advantage then hath the Jew? or what profit is there of circumcision? Much every way: chiefly, because that unto them were committed the oracles of God.” (Romans 3:1–2)

The Apostle Paul states that Israel’s greatest privilege was not their land, nor their kings, nor even their temple, but that to them was entrusted the very Word of God. The Old Testament was not haphazardly scattered among nations, nor was its keeping given over to pagan philosophers. It was committed to the Jews, specifically to the Levites and priests, by God himself.

1. Custody Given by God Himself

From day one, God tied the keeping of His words to His covenant people.

- Deut. 31:24–26 — When Moses finished the law, he gave it to the Levites to keep beside the ark.
- Mal. 2:7 — The priest's lips "should keep knowledge," and people should seek the law from him.
- Deut. 17:18–19 — Even kings had to copy the law from the scrolls "before the priests the Levites." No freelancing.

And they didn't treat copying like casual bookwork. Jewish scribes counted lines, words, even letters; standardized columns and line lengths; noted statistics (*Masorah parva/magna*); tracked *Qere/Ketiv* to preserve both reading and written form; and destroyed flawed scrolls rather than pass them on.[20] The Masoretes (A.D. 500–1000) organized all this, stabilized spelling and spacing, added vowels and accents to protect public reading, and guarded a conservative text. That's not a game of telephone. That's stewardship. It's why the Dead Sea Scrolls, centuries

[20] This meticulous process is described in detail by scholars of the Hebrew Bible's transmission. The rules governing the production of sacred scrolls were recorded in the Talmudic tractate Soferim. See Emanuel Tov, Textual criticism of the Hebrew Bible, 3rd ed. (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2012), 31–39.

older, ended up confirming the Masoretic line instead of overturning it.

2. Contrast with Greek Handling of the Text

Modern critics often put the Septuagint on a pedestal. But biblically, God never commissioned Gentile kings or philosophers to preserve His law. He warned against trusting Egypt (Isa. 30:1–2). Alexandria, in particular, is tied to doctrinal corruption. God chose the Jews to guard His oracles.

So, the question of authority doesn't get settled by the Letter of Aristeas or fourth-century Greek codices. Scripture itself says God gave the keeping of His words to Israel and kept them there.

Any claim that pagan scholars working for Ptolemaic Egypt had equal authority with God's Levites in Jerusalem simply contradicts God's assignment of scripture's custody. Faith demands we start where God told us: **with the Jews and their Hebrew text.**

3. The Character of Jewish Transmission

The Jewish scribes, later known as the Masoretes, copied with meticulous care. They counted letters, checked

column lengths, and destroyed defective scrolls.[21] M. Burrows, in his 1948 study of the Dead Sea Scrolls, remarked of the Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa[a]): *"It is substantially the book preserved in the Masoretic Text."* [22] Even the earlier Isaiah "B" scroll agreed even more closely with the Masoretic.[23]

This shows that long before Christ walked the earth, the Hebrew text had already been preserved faithfully in the Jewish community. The Dead Sea Scrolls, dating to 100–175 B.C., align overwhelmingly with the Masoretic tradition.

4. A Faith-Based Conclusion

The Bible is not silent on who had the Word. It was not Alexandria. It was not Rome. It was not Greek philosophers or eclectic compilers. It was the Jews, men chosen and commanded by God to be guardians of His oracles.

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[21] Babylonian Talmud, *Kiddushin* 30a, in *The Talmud of Babylonia: A Translation and Commentary*, ed. Jacob Neusner (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 2011).

[22] Millar Burrows, *The Dead Sea Scrolls* (New York: Viking Press, 1955), 304.

[23] Gleason L. Archer Jr., *A Survey of Old Testament Introduction*, Rev. ed. (Chicago: Moody Press, 1994), 29. Archer notes that the second Isaiah scroll (1QIsab) "turned out to be even closer to the Masoretic Text."

This fact shows why the King James Bible, based on the **Hebrew Masoretic Text**, stands as the faithful Old Testament. It is rooted in the line God Himself authorized, not in the unauthorized experiments of Alexandrian translators.

B. EVIDENCE: MASORETIC TEXT AND THE DEAD SEA SCROLLS

The King James Bible's Old Testament is built squarely on the **Masoretic Text**, the Hebrew text preserved and standardized by Jewish scribes. Critics often dismiss the Masoretic Text as "late," suggesting it was compiled centuries after Christ and therefore unreliable. But the evidence, both biblical and archaeological, demonstrates otherwise.

1. The Dead Sea Scrolls Confirm the Masoretic Text

When the Dead Sea Scrolls were discovered between 1947 and 1956, liberal scholars expected them to undermine the Masoretic Text. Instead, they vindicated it.

- The **Great Isaiah Scroll (1QIsa^{a})**, dated around 125 B.C., is almost identical to the Masoretic text of Isaiah that underlies our KJV.[24] The word of Peter Flint, a leading Dead Sea Scrolls scholar, shows that 1QIsab has been classified as proto-Masoretic

[24] Archer, *A Survey of Old Testament Introduction*, 29. Archer states, "A comparison of 1QIsa with the Masoretic Hebrew text of Isaiah revealed an amazing degree of agreement... The 166 words present in 1QIsa for this chapter vary from the Masoretic text in only ten letters... a 95 percent degree of accuracy."

in view of its general affinity with the Masoretic text.[25]

- **Isaiah B** scroll agrees even more closely with the Masoretic Text, showing not corruption but that it is in fact representative of the "oldest and best" manuscripts and preserved in the most ancient form.

- Statistical analysis of the scrolls shows that **about 60% of them align with the Masoretic Text**;[26] only a tiny fraction (about 5%) align with Septuagint readings.[27]

This means that over a century before Christ, faithful Jews were already using the Masoretic line as their standard.

2. Archeological Support

[25] Peter W. Flint, "The Interpretation of Scriptural Isaiah in the Qumran Scrolls: Quotations, Citations, Allusions, and the Form of the Scriptural Source Text," in *A Teacher for All Generations: Essays in Honor of James C. VanderKam*, ed. Eric F. Mason et al., vol. 1 of *Supplements to the Journal for the Study of Judaism* 153 (Leiden: Brill, 2012), 389–406.

[26] Emanuel Tov, *Textual Criticism of the Hebrew Bible*, 3rd ed. (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 2012), 107–108.

[27] Lawrence H. Schiffman, *Reclaiming the Dead Sea Scrolls* (Philadelphia: Jewish Publication Society, 1994), 138. (On the textual character of the scrolls: ≈60% proto-Masoretic, ≈5% proto-Samaritan, ≈5% Septuagintal, remainder non-aligned/Qumran practice.)

Other finds confirm that the Masoretic Text reflects the oldest forms of Hebrew writing:

- The **Tel Dan Stele**, an archaeological inscription from the **9th century B.C**., spells David's name as "DWD" (דוד), without the vowel points or inserted letters. Interestingly, the Great Isaiah Scroll (from ~125 B.C.) spells David as "DWYD" (דיוד), reflecting the updated linguistic/spelling trends of the time. However, the Masoretic Text keeps the older form "DWD," matching the 9th-century Tel Dan Stele. Showing that even "later" Masoretic manuscripts are in fact showing that the Masoretic text is more ancient in spelling, language, and linguistic patterns than the oldest known manuscripts (Dead Sea Scrolls). They reflect an even older writing and spelling style. From this we can conclude that they are closer to the original writings than any existing manuscripts today.

- In 2021, new fragments were discovered in the "Cave of Horror" near the Dead Sea, Greek fragments of Zechariah and Nahum.[28] The Israel

[28] Israel Antiquities Authority, "New Fragments of Biblical Scroll Discovered in the Judean Desert," March 16, 2021, https://www.antiquities.org.il.

Antiquities Authority concluded: *"The texts reflect an early Jewish scribal tradition close to the Masoretic base."*[29]

These discoveries demolish the claim that the Masoretic Text is a "late corruption." Instead, they show it represents the conservative, carefully guarded text that traces directly back to the priests and Levites entrusted with God's word (Deut. 31:24–26).

4. Jesus and the Masoretic Text

Jesus and the apostles quoted from the Hebrew text preserved by the Jews, not from Greek alternatives.

- *Matthew 5:18* — "Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled." Jots and tittles are Hebrew marks, not Greek.

- *Luke 24:44* — Jesus summarized the OT canon as "the law of Moses, the prophets, and the psalms"—the three divisions of the Hebrew Masoretic text,

[29] This refers to the 2021 discovery of new fragments from the Bar Kokhba Revolt period. The findings were announced in an official press release. Israel Antiquities Authority, "For the First Time in 60 Years, Archaeological Excavations Have Uncovered Scrolls," news release, March 16, 2021.

not the broader Alexandrian canon with the Apocrypha.

Thus, the Masoretic Text is not only vindicated by archaeology but endorsed by Christ Himself.

C. WHAT THE SEPTUAGINT IS (AND ISN'T)

The greatest rival to the Masoretic Text is the **Septuagint (LXX)**, a Greek translation often claimed to date to 250 B.C. and sometimes suggested as the Old Testament text favored by the apostles. But the truth is much less certain, and far less flattering.

The Modern Claim

If you read in a seminary textbook, you'll likely see statements like:

- *"The Septuagint was translated around 250 B.C. in Alexandria by seventy-two Jewish scholars."*
- *"Jesus and the apostles quoted from the Septuagint."*
- *"The Septuagint is the Bible of the early church."*

These lines are repeated so often that they give the impression of a concrete, unified, ancient Greek Old Testament, existing centuries before Christ, and universally used.

The Historical Evidence: But what do we *actually* have?

1. The Letter of Aristeas and the Legend of Origins

The traditional story comes from the *Letter of Aristeas*, which claims that Ptolemy II Philadelphus (3rd century B.C.) summoned 72 Jewish elders to Alexandria to translate the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek for his library. According to the legend, they miraculously produced identical translations.

But this account is riddled with problems:

- The letter itself is a **second-century forgery**, filled with mythical embellishments.[30]
- Even if true, it only speaks of the **Torah (first five books)**, not the entire Old Testament.
- It contradicts the biblical reality that God entrusted the copying and teaching of the law to the **Levites**, not to Jews from other unauthorized tribes working for a pagan king (Deut. 17:18–19; Mal. 2:7).

2. The Septuagint Manuscripts We Actually Have

There is no extant manuscript of a full "Septuagint" before the Christian era.

[30] Karen H. Jobes and Moisés Silva, *Invitation to the Septuagint*, 2nd ed. (Grand Rapids: Baker Academic, 2015), 37–41. Modern scholars nearly unanimously regard the *Letter of Aristeas* as pseudepigraphical, likely composed in the second century B.C., to lend authority to the Greek translation.

- The earliest known fragment (Rylands Papyrus, ~150 B.C.) contains only a sliver of Deuteronomy.[31]
- The first complete Greek Old Testament is found in **Origen's Hexapla (c. 200 A.D.)**, which mixed multiple Greek versions and intermingled the Apocrypha with Scripture.[32]
- The "great" uncials, **Vaticanus** and **Sinaiticus** (4th century), contain the so-called "Septuagint" but with heavy Origenic influence, including the Apocrypha presented as Scripture .

Thus, the "Septuagint" as cited in modern scholarship is not an ancient, unified text, but a shifting collection of Greek translations, heavily shaped by Alexandrian hands.

RECAP: Do We Actually Have Historical Evidence for the Septuagint?

1. **The Letter of Aristeas**

[31] Papyrus Rylands 458 (P.Ryl. 458) is generally accepted as the earliest extant manuscript of the Septuagint. C. H. Roberts, ed., *Two Biblical Papyri in the John Rylands Library, Manchester* (Manchester: Manchester University Press, 1936).

[32] Origen's massive six-column work is the first known attempt to produce a critical and comprehensive edition of the Old Testament, though no complete manuscript of it survives. The remaining fragments were famously collected by Frederick Field, *Origenis Hexaplorum quae supersunt*, 2 vols. (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1875).

- The only ancient story about the Septuagint's origin comes from the *Letter of Aristeas* (2nd century B.C.).
- This letter is widely regarded by modern scholars, even critical ones, as a piece of **legendary propaganda**, filled with improbable details.
- Even if true, it only speaks about the Torah (Genesis–Deuteronomy), not the entire Old Testament.

2. **The Earliest Fragments**

- The earliest physical fragment sometimes connected to a Greek OT (Papyrus Rylands 458, Deuteronomy) dates to around 150 B.C.
- It is just a small scrap, not a unified Bible.
- There is no evidence of a complete "Septuagint" codex until **Origen's Hexapla** (~200 A.D.).

3. **Origen's Hexapla**

- Origen (3rd century A.D.) compiled a massive work comparing six different

versions of the Old Testament, including Hebrew and several Greek translations.
    - The so-called “Septuagint” text within it was already mixed with variant readings and with **Apocryphal books interspersed**.
    - This shows there wasn’t a fixed Septuagint, but multiple shifting Greek renderings.

4. **The “Great” Uncials (Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, Alexandrinus)**

    - These 4th–5th century manuscripts are the first time we see a nearly full “Septuagint.”
    - But they differ from each other, contain corrections, and mix in Apocrypha as though it were Scripture.
    - They are **600–700 years later** than the supposed 250 B.C. translation event!

3. Problems with Relying on the Septuagint

- **It undermines Jewish custody of Scripture.** God never gave Gentiles authority over His Word.
- **It includes the Apocrypha.** By the time it appears in complete manuscripts, it has intermingled Tobit, Judith, Maccabees, and others, which Jesus and the apostles never treated as Scripture.

- **It disagrees with the Hebrew.** The Septuagint often diverges from the Masoretic Text, not with innocent paraphrase but with doctrinal implications (e.g., changes in messianic prophecies).

4. Did Jesus and the Apostles Use the Septuagint?

This is a common claim, but it falls apart under scrutiny:

- Many NT quotations said to be "from the LXX" can be explained as Spirit-guided translations or paraphrases from Hebrew.
- When Jesus read Scripture publicly (Luke 4:17–21), it was from the **Hebrew scroll of Isaiah**, not from a Greek translation.[33]
- The apostles wrote in Greek, but their citations harmonize most consistently with the **Masoretic base**, not with Alexandrian variants.

Conclusion of the Old Testament Section

The evidence is overwhelming:

- God committed His Word to the Jews.

[33] Craig A. Evans, *Jesus and His World: The Archaeological Evidence* (Louisville, KY: Westminster John Knox Press, 2012), 81.

- The Masoretic Text is confirmed by Scripture, history, and archaeology.
- The Dead Sea Scrolls demonstrate its antiquity and stability.
- The Septuagint, far from being a superior witness, is a patchwork product of Alexandria, tainted with the Apocrypha and contradictions.

Thus, when the King James translators built their Old Testament on the Masoretic Hebrew text, they were standing in the line God Himself ordained. Far from being "late," it is the **only legitimate Old Testament base**, vindicated by both the Bible and the witness of time.

A. THE TEXT THE CHURCH ACTUALLY USED

When critics debate New Testament manuscripts, their attention often centers on the so-called "oldest and best" Alexandrian codices, Vaticanus, Sinaiticus, and Alexandrinus. But the critical question is not simply, *Which manuscript is the oldest that still survives?* The real question is, *What text did the body of Christ actually receive, preach, and copy from the very beginning?*

Scripture itself provides the standard for how this works:

- **Acts 2:42** — "And they continued stedfastly in the apostles' doctrine…"
- **2 Timothy 2:2** — Paul charged Timothy to entrust the words he had heard to "faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also."
- **Colossians 4:16** — Letters were circulated among the churches and read publicly.

From its earliest days, the New Testament was not treated as a museum artifact but as a living text. Believers used it constantly, reading it aloud, copying it, memorizing it, preaching it, and passing it down.

This explains why the Majority Text (the Antiochan or Textus Receptus line) does not always appear in the oldest surviving material forms, though it does in some. It was the working Bible of the churches, worn out through regular use. Like a carpenter's hammer, it bore the marks of labor and life. In contrast, the Alexandrian codices are "old" not because they were superior, but because they were largely left unused. The church called the traditional line the *Textus Receptus*—"the received text"—because it was the text received, employed, and faithfully copied by the New Testament church.

Dean John Burgon, the nineteenth-century defender of the Received Text, showed that the church's witness to this text was not a late development but an ancient one. He said:[34]

> "Lectionaries abound, which establish the Text which has been publicly read in the churches of the East, from at least A.D. 400 until the time of the invention of printing."

He further noted:[35]

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[34] John William Burgon, The Revision Revised (London: John Murray, 1883), 37.

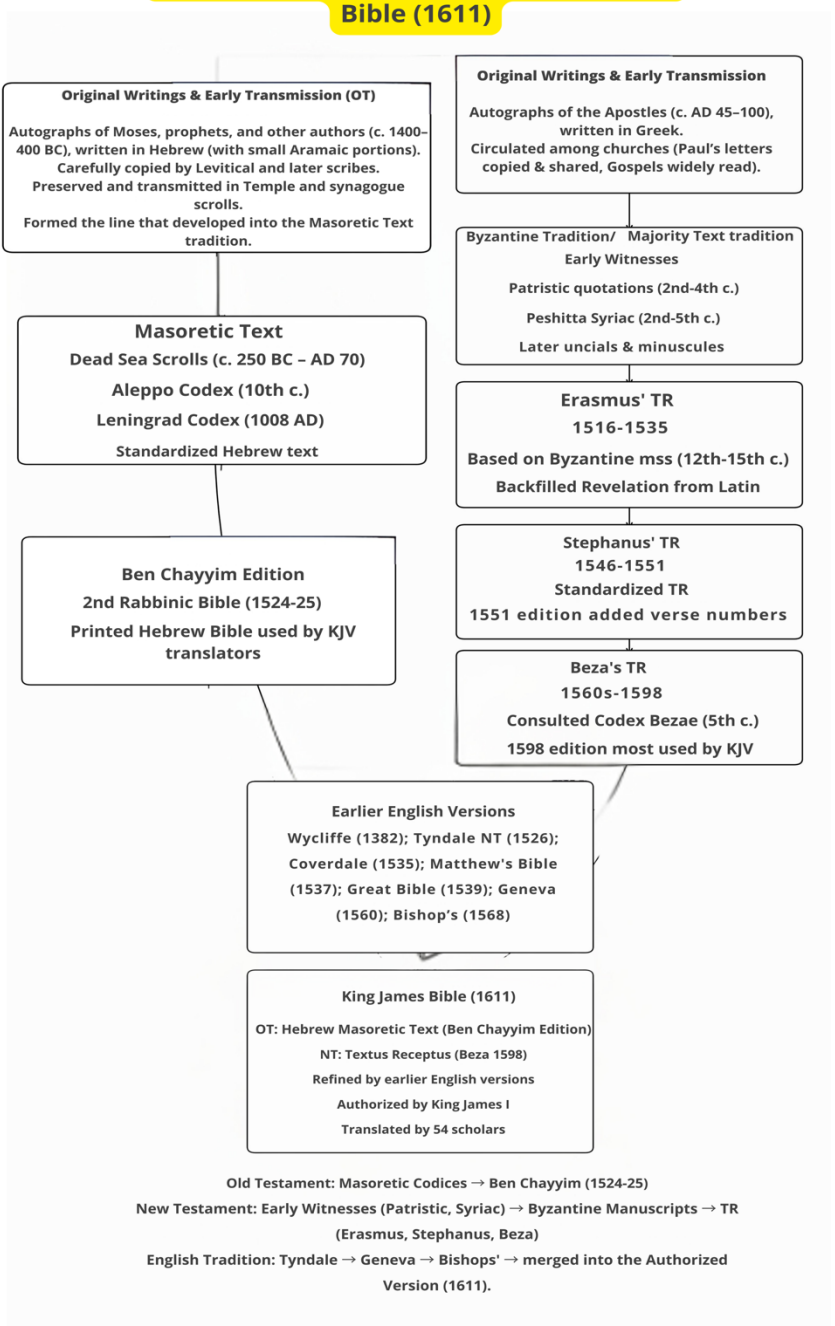
[35] John William Burgon, The Revision Revised (London: John Murray, 1883), 401.

> “The Textus Receptus was universally employed throughout Europe for the first 300 years after the invention of printing… being more than 1500 years old”

That is the testimony of the church.

And just as the Old Testament priests were entrusted with the custody of the Law, so the New Testament priesthood of believers has been entrusted with the custody of the Scriptures. The responsibility for guarding, teaching, and transmitting God’s Word passed from the Levites to the church. The “royal priesthood” (1 Pet. 2:9; Rev. 1:6) received the text, preserved it through constant use, and faithfully handed it down from generation to generation. The text that the Holy Spirit moved the church to embrace was the Majority Text, the Textus Receptus from Antioch in Syria, the very text upon which the King James Bible was built.

Transmission of Texts to the King James Bible (1611)



Old Testament: Masoretic Codices → Ben Chayyim (1524-25)

New Testament: Early Witnesses (Patristic, Syriac) → Byzantine Manuscripts → TR (Erasmus, Stephanus, Beza)

English Tradition: Tyndale → Geneva → Bishops' → merged into the Authorized Version (1611).

B. EVIDENCE: MANUSCRIPTS, VERSIONS, AND FATHERS

1. Manuscript Evidence

The numbers speak loudly:

- There are **5,255 extant Greek NT manuscripts**.
- Of these, about **5,210 (95–98%)** support the Byzantine/Textus Receptus line.[36]
- Fewer than **50 manuscripts** reflect the Alexandrian/Western line, and among those, only **three (B, א, A)** form the backbone of the modern critical text.

Some newer studies done, show an updated manuscript count:[37]

- **Total Count:** Approximately **5,700 to 5,800** Greek manuscripts.

[36] Wilbur N. Pickering, *The Identity of the New Testament Text* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 1977), 155–56.

[37] Institute for New Testament Textual Research (INTF), "The Greek Manuscripts of the New Testament," *New Testament Virtual Manuscript Room (NTVMR)*, University of Münster, accessed [08/30/2025], https://ntvmr.uni-muenster.de/.

- This is the current working estimate from the **Institut für Neutestamentliche Textforschung (INTF)**, the official cataloging body, as of September 2023.

Text-Type Breakdown

- **Antioch (Byzantine) Text:** 75.9% of the sample
- **Alexandrian Text:** 3.6% of the sample
- **Other types** (Eclectic/Caesarean, Egyptian, and Western): 20.5% of the sample

The sheer weight of numbers indicates what the church used, copied, and passed down.

Zane Hodges (former **Professor or New Testament at Dallas Theological Seminary**) and Dr. John Walvoord (former **President of Dallas Theological Seminary**), said this about the Majority Text,[38]

> "The manuscript tradition of an ancient book will, under any but the most exceptional conditions, multiply in a reasonably regular fashion with the result that the copies nearest the autograph will normally have the largest number of descendants…

[38] Zane C. Hodges, "Modern Textual Criticism and the Majority Text: A Defense," *Bibliotheca Sacra* 125, no. 517 (January–March 1968): 1.

> Thus the Majority text, upon which the King James Version is based, has in reality the strongest claim possible to be regarded as an authentic representation of the original text."

What they are saying is that the manuscripts that are most numerable, will by their very nature, resemble the original writings the most. This is the Majority Text, the base for the New Testament of the King James Bible.

This same idea was admitted to by **Fenton John Anthony Hort,** one of the two originators of the first "modern version" of the Bible, using the Alexandrian manuscripts,[39]

> "A theoretical presumption indeed remains that a majority of extant documents is more likely to represent a majority of ancestral documents at each stage of transmission than *vice versa."*

2. Early Versions

The early translations confirm this picture:

- **Peshitta Syriac (100–150 A.D.)** — aligns with the Byzantine tradition.

[39] B. F. Westcott and F. J. A. Hort, *The New Testament in the Original Greek,* II, p. 45.

- **P66 (100-200 A.D.)** — aligns with the TR in more places than any Alexandrian MSS.[40]
- **P45 (200 A.D.)** — aligns with the TR in more places than any Alexandrian MSS.[41]
- **Old Latin (Itala, 2nd century)** — also reflects the Received Text.
- These versions circulated in living Christian communities, showing what believers on the ground actually read and preached. Also showing that the "older and better" claims are simply untrue.

3. Patristic Quotations

The church fathers ("fathers" is not a term I like to use here (Matt. 23:9) but for the sake of clarity and how they are referred to in history, I will use it) quote the Byzantine/TR line extensively:

- From **69 A.D. (Polycarp, disciple of John)** through **400 A.D.**, over **2,630 quotations** reflect the TR.[42]

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[40] A. F. J. Klijn, *A Survey of the Researches into the Western Text of the Gospels and Acts, Part 2, 1949-1969* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1969), as cited in Wilbur N. Pickering, *The Identity of the New Testament Text VI* (2024), p. 55.

[41] Ibid

[42] Frederic G. Kenyon, Handbook to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament (London: Macmillan, 1901), 375–76

- Irenaeus (130–200 A.D.), disciple of Polycarp, quoted verses like Mark 16:9–20 and 1 John 5:7 as Scripture, verses cut out of modern critical editions.[43]
- Cyprian (200–258 A.D.) referenced the Trinity of 1 John 5:7 (*"and these three are one"*), centuries before Vaticanus and Sinaiticus would omit it.[44]

Thus, the claim that these readings are "late additions" is demolished by the very voices of the earliest post-apostolic generations.

[43] Irenaeus explicitly quotes Mark 16:19 in his work *Against Heresies* 3.10.6, providing definitive second-century evidence for the longer ending of Mark.

[44] In his treatise *On the Unity of the Church*, Cyprian writes, "The Lord says, 'I and the Father are one'; and again it is written of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, 'And these three are one.'" Cyprian, *De Unitate Ecclesiae*, 6. This is considered by many to be the earliest clear reference to the *Comma Johanneum*.

C. THE ALEXANDRIAN CLUSTER (B, א, A) IN CONTEXT

Modern textual critics place immense weight on **three manuscripts**:

- **Codex Vaticanus (B, ~350 A.D.)**
- **Codex Sinaiticus (א, ~350 A.D.)**
- **Codex Alexandrinus (A, ~400–450 A.D.)**

These are often called the “oldest and best.” But history and inspection show otherwise.

1. Vaticanus (B)

Codex **Vaticanus**, known by the letter **B**, is regarded by modern textual critics as one of the two “crown jewels” of their discipline (alongside **Sinaiticus**). It is leaned upon more heavily than any other manuscript in shaping the modern critical text of the Greek New Testament. Nearly every modern translation (NIV, ESV, NASB, CSB, etc.) gives Vaticanus priority when its readings differ from the Traditional Text, making it one of the most influential documents behind the wording of the Bibles read in churches today.

Vaticanus is generally dated to the **fourth century** (**around A.D. 325–350**).[45] Some scholars believe it may have been one of the fifty copies of Scripture that the **Roman Emperor Constantine** ordered to be made for the churches of Constantinople, as recorded by the historian **Eusebius**.[46] A. T Robertson was convinced this was the origin of Vaticanus,[47]

> "Constantine himself ordered fifty Greek Bibles from Eusebius, Bishop of Caesarea, for the churches in Constantinople. It is quite possible that ,Ñμ and B are two of these fifty, though the actual copying was probably done in Egypt or by Egyptian scribes."

Its very origin story highlights the difference between a Bible handed down through the Spirit-led people of God and one produced under the influence of a Pagan Roman Emperor.

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[45] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989), 106–9.

[46] Eusebius of Caesarea, *Life of Constantine* 4.36–37, in *Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers*, Second Series, Vol. 1, ed. Philip Schaff and Henry Wace (New York: Christian Literature Publishing, 1890), 544.

[47] A. T. Robertson, An Introduction to the Textual Criticism of the New Testament (Nashville: Sunday School Board of the Southern Baptist Convention, 1925), 80.

The manuscript itself bears the marks of corruption and incompleteness. It is **missing large portions** of the New Testament: everything from Hebrews 9:14 onward, the Pastoral Epistles (1–2 Timothy, Titus), Philemon, and the book of Revelation. In addition to these omissions, Vaticanus includes **apocryphal** material alongside canonical Scripture, mixing the inspired Word of God with uninspired writings.

After its production, Vaticanus eventually came to rest in **Rome**, where it was placed in the **Vatican** Library. Remarkably, it sat there for centuries unused, until appearing in a catalog in 1481. Unlike the manuscripts copied and worn thin through centuries of church use, Vaticanus survived precisely because it was not trusted or used in the life of the churches. It was a shelf relic, not a living text among the people of God.

And yet, despite this history of neglect, modern scholarship now exalts Vaticanus as one of the “oldest and best” witnesses to the New Testament text. In reality, its survival tells a different story: it was preserved by disuse, not by providential transmission through the believing church. To rest the authority of modern Bibles on such a manuscript, rather than on the Received Text preserved and used in the churches for fifteen centuries, is to lean on a witness rejected by the very body of Christ.

2. Sinaiticus (א)

Codex Sinaiticus, designated by the Hebrew letter **א (Aleph)**, is considered by modern textual critics to be the twin authority alongside Vaticanus (B). J.F Fenlon wrote about the origination of Sinaiticus from Alexandria, Egypt, connecting it back to Origen as well,[48]

> "It seems to have been at one time at Caesarea; one of the correctors (probably of seventh century) adds this note at the end of Esdras: 'This codex was compared with a very ancient exemplar which had been corrected by the hand of the holy martyr Pamphilus [d. 309]; which exemplar contained at the end the subscription in his own hand: "Taken and corrected according to the Hexapla of Origen: Antonius compared it: I, Pamphilus, corrected it.'… The text of Codex Sinaiticus bears a very close resemblance to that of Codex Vaticanus…"

Together, these two manuscripts form the backbone of the Nestle-Aland and UBS critical editions of the Greek New Testament, which in turn underlie nearly every modern Bible translation (NIV, ESV, NASB, CSB, etc.). In practice, Sinaiticus and Vaticanus are given priority over the

[48] J. F. Fenlon, "Codex Sinaiticus," The Catholic Encyclopedia 4 (New York: Robert Appleton, 1908). 85-86

thousands of manuscripts that agree with the Traditional Text, making them the “pillars” of the modern text-critical approach.

Sinaiticus is generally dated to the mid**-fourth century (c. A.D. 330–360**)[49], with many scholars suggesting it, too, may have been among the fifty Bibles ordered by Constantine and produced in Alexandria. It is written in Greek uncials on vellum and originally contained the entire Old and New Testaments, though much of the Old Testament has been lost. Unlike the manuscripts faithfully copied and worn out through centuries of church use, Sinaiticus survived because it was preserved in obscurity.

The discovery story itself underscores its questionable history. In the mid-19th century, Constantin von Tischendorf famously found parts of the manuscript at St. Catherine’s Monastery at Mount Sinai, some of which, according to his own report, were sitting in a wastebasket, destined to be burned. Other portions he retrieved later under circumstances still disputed. This means one of the primary witnesses for modern Bibles literally comes from a trash pile, rejected even by monks who were otherwise careful to preserve manuscripts.

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[49] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989), 106–9.

The text of Sinaiticus reveals why it was discarded. It contains **thousands of corrections** made by different scribes over centuries, with some estimating more than **14,000 individual alterations**. In some places, Sinaiticus **contradicts itself within just a few verses**, and in others, it departs radically from the Traditional Text and from parallel passages. For example, in the Gospels it frequently shortens or alters verses, and in the New Testament as a whole it shows a tendency toward omissions, particularly in Christological passages.

In addition to the canonical Scriptures, Sinaiticus includes books not recognized as inspired: the *Epistle of Barnabas* and the *Shepherd of Hermas.* Their presence once again blurs the line between God's Word and uninspired writings.

And yet, despite its origin in neglect, its internal contradictions, and its long centuries of obscurity, Codex Sinaiticus is treated by modern scholarship as one of the "oldest and best" witnesses. In reality, its checkered history and heavily corrected text argue the opposite: it survived not by providence through the churches, but by disuse, rejection, and accident.

3. Alexandrinus (A)

Codex Alexandrinus, designated **A**, is usually dated to the early **fifth century (c. A.D. 400–440**)[50]. Unlike Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, it surfaced earlier in the West and was presented to King James I's successor, Charles I of England, in 1627. Today it resides in the British Library. While often cited by modern textual critics, Alexandrinus has always been considered less consistent and less "pure" than Vaticanus or Sinaiticus.

The manuscript was likely produced in Alexandria, Egypt, and, true to its origin, it shows a **mixture of text types** rather than a unified, reliable witness. In the Gospels, Alexandrinus leans toward the Byzantine text-type (closer to the Traditional Text), but in Acts and the Epistles it frequently follows Alexandrian readings, and in Revelation it exhibits a unique text all its own. This inconsistency makes it an unstable witness, sometimes supporting the Received Text, sometimes departing from it in favor of Alexandrian corruption.

Like the other "great uncials," Alexandrinus also contains the **Apocrypha** intermixed with canonical books, once again blurring the lines between inspired and uninspired writings. Its inclusion of non-canonical works is another

[50] Kurt Aland and Barbara Aland, *The Text of the New Testament: An Introduction to the Critical Editions and to the Theory and Practice of Modern Textual Criticism*, 2nd ed., trans. Erroll F. Rhodes (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989), 106–9.

reminder that these manuscripts were not safeguarded by the churches of God, but arose from the Alexandrian stream where human philosophy and textual alteration flourished.

While Vaticanus and Sinaiticus are the primary authorities leaned upon by modern editors, Alexandrinus is treated as a secondary witness, valuable when it agrees with their preferred readings, but inconsistent and less trusted overall. Yet despite its mixed character, modern translations will still occasionally follow Alexandrinus where it supports a critical variant against the Traditional Text.

In the end, Alexandrinus stands as another example of a manuscript preserved not by faithful usage in the churches, but by storage in obscure collections, reflecting the instability of the Alexandrian textual tradition.

Critics hail these codices as “old” and therefore superior. But age without use is no virtue. These manuscripts were preserved in good condition precisely because the churches rejected them. They were locked away or abandoned, not worn out in service.

Burgon again remarked:

> *"It is in fact easier to find two consecutive verses in which B and א differ, than two consecutive verses in which they agree."* [51]

The problem is not just that these manuscripts disagree with the text preserved and used by the churches, they also disagree with themselves. **Codex Sinaiticus (א)** has layer upon layer of corrections made by different scribes over the centuries. In some places, whole sections were rewritten multiple times, showing confusion rather than stability. **Codex Vaticanus (B)** is marked by unusual omissions and even cancellations, and its copyists left notes in the margins warning readers about questionable spots, hardly the sign of a manuscript people fully trusted. And when Vaticanus and Sinaiticus do "agree," they just as often contradict one another a few lines later. Together they do not form a strong, consistent witness, but a shaky and shifting one. Their very inconsistency helps explain why these books were left unused long enough to survive. That is not the mark of the "oldest and best", it is the mark of instability.

D. Exhibit Chapter: At-a-Glance Plates

To visualize the divide, we can picture two streams:

[51] John William Burgon, *The Revision Revised* (London: John Murray, 1883), 37-38.

- **The Majority/Byzantine Line (Antioch → TR → Reformation Bibles → KJV)**
    - 5,200+ MSS in agreement.
    - Confirmed by early versions (Old Latin, Syriac).
    - Quoted extensively by fathers like Polycarp, Irenaeus, Cyprian.
    - Produced the Bibles of the Reformation and the Great Awakenings.
- **The Minority/Alexandrian Line (Alexandria → Vaticanus/Sinaiticus → Critical Text → Modern Versions)**
    - Fewer than 50 MSS.
    - Riddled with contradictions.
    - Preserved in institutions, not in churches.
    - Forms the base for hundreds of conflicting modern versions since 1881.

Conclusion of the New Testament Section

The real question is not, “Which manuscript is oldest?” but rather, “Which text did the church actually use?” By every line of evidence, manuscript count, early versions, patristic quotations, historical fruit, and even age, the answer is the Textus Receptus, not the Alexandrian cluster.

The NT text of the King James Bible is not an accident of history. It is the **received text**, preserved in the life of the church, vindicated by the earliest Christians, and blessed by the Holy Ghost in revival and missions.

"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away" (Matt. 24:35).

And indeed, His words have not.

DOCTRINAL ISSUES (WHY THE "SMALL" CHANGES AREN'T SMALL)

We often hear people say, "The differences between Bible versions don't change any doctrines." But when you slow down and actually compare them side by side, you find that these "small changes" add up to very big differences. In fact, some of the clearest teachings about Jesus, salvation, and the Christian life are blurred or weakened in modern versions. Let's walk through some key examples.

1 Timothy 3:16
KJV: *"God was manifest in the flesh."*
NIV: *"He was manifested in the flesh."*
In the KJV, Paul is boldly declaring that **God Himself** came down into human flesh. That's one of the strongest confirmations of Jesus' deity in the New Testament. The NIV and other modern Bibles switch it to "He," which is vague. Everyone is "manifested in the flesh." Only the KJV preserves the force of this verse, that Jesus is God made flesh.

Philippians 2:5–6

KJV: *"Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God."*
ESV: *"Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped."*

The difference is subtle but huge. The KJV says Jesus didn't have to grasp for equality with God, it was already His by nature. He was fully God. The ESV makes it sound like Jesus did not think he was/could be equal to God. The KJV defends the truth that Jesus has always been equal with God.

John 1:18
KJV: *"the only begotten Son."*
ESV: *"the only God."*

The KJV preserves the unique Father and Son relationship. Modern versions wording creates confusion, how can the "only God" be "at the Father's side" (as the ESV says) if they are the same Person? The KJV clearly teaches that the Son is distinct from the Father, yet fully God.

Romans 14:10
KJV: *"…for we shall all stand before the judgment seat of Christ."*

NASB: *"…for we will all stand before the judgment seat of God."*

The KJV highlights that **Jesus Christ** is the one who will judge all mankind, consistent with John 5:22 where the Father has committed judgment to the Son. Modern versions shift the focus back to "God," which is true, but less specific. It hides the explicit statement that Jesus is the final Judge.

1 Corinthians 10:9

KJV: *"Neither let us tempt Christ, as some of them also tempted."*

NASB: *"Nor are we to put the Lord to the test, as some of them."*

At first glance they look the same. But this is really important: Paul is identifying the God of the Old Testament whom Israel tempted in the wilderness as **Christ Himself**. That means Jesus is the God of the Old Testament, the LORD. This strong doctrinal connection disappears in most modern translations that don't keep the precise wording.

Luke 24:52

KJV: *"And they worshipped him, and returned to Jerusalem with great joy."*

RSV: *"And they returned to Jerusalem with great joy,*

The KJV confidently states the disciples worshipped the risen Jesus. Some modern versions question or bracket the wording or remove it all together. Why downplay one of the clearest moments of the disciples bowing before their Lord?

Acts 20:28

KJV: *"…the church of God, which he hath purchased with his own blood."*

ESV: *"…the church of God, which he obtained with the blood of his own."*

The KJV makes the point blunt: it was **God's own blood**, Christ's blood, that bought the church. The ESV rephrases it so the link between God and the blood of Christ is less direct.

1 John 5:7–8

KJV: *"For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one."*

NIV: *"For there are three that testify."*

The KJV includes the classic "heavenly witnesses" verse, which is one of the clearest verses on the doctrine of the trinity in the Bible. Modern versions drop it completely or

put it in the footnotes. This removes one of the strongest proof-texts for the trinity in the whole Bible.

Luke 2:33

KJV: *"And Joseph and his mother marvelled at those things which were spoken of him."*

ESV: *"And his father and his mother marveled at what was said about him."*

The KJV avoids calling Joseph Jesus' father, which protects the doctrine of the virgin birth. The ESV uses "father," which could give the wrong impression.

Luke 2:22

KJV: *"…the days of **her** purification…"*

CSB: *"…the days of **their** purification…"*

The law of Moses only required the purification of the mother, not both parents. The KJV gets it right.

Matthew 1:25

KJV: *"…and knew her not till she had brought forth her firstborn son."*

NET: *"…but knew her not until she had given birth to a son."*

The word “firstborn” matters. It tells us Mary had other children after Jesus, countering the Roman Catholic teaching of her perpetual virginity.

Daniel 3:25

KJV: *“…the form of the fourth is like the Son of God.”*

NASB: *“…the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods.”*

The KJV points to Christ as the fourth man in the fire. The NASB makes it sound like Nebuchadnezzar just saw a pagan deity.

Colossians 1:14

KJV: *“…redemption through his blood, even the forgiveness of sins.”*

NIV: *“…redemption, the forgiveness of sins.”*

Taking out “through his blood” removes the very means of redemption. Without the blood of Christ, there is no forgiveness.

Acts 8:37

KJV: *“…And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.”*

CSB: Omitted, footnote only.

This verse contains the Ethiopian eunuch's confession of faith **before** baptism. Leaving it out removes a key testimony that salvation is by faith in Christ before baptism.

Acts 9:6

KJV: *"…Lord, what wilt thou have me to do?"*

ESV: Shorter; Paul's cry is missing.

The KJV records Paul's first words of surrender to the Lord. Without them, the dramatic conversion moment loses some of its impact.

Matthew 18:11

KJV: *"For the Son of man is come to save that which was lost."*

NABS: Verse omitted.

This is a clear purpose statement of why Jesus came, to save the lost. Why remove it?

John 6:47

KJV: *"…He that believeth on me hath everlasting life."*

NIV: *"…the one who believes has eternal life."*

Dropping "on me" weakens the focus. Faith isn't just a vague belief, it must be in Christ.

Isaiah 14:12 / Revelation 22:16

KJV Isa. 14:12: *"How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning!"*
NIV Isa. 14:12: *How you have fallen from heaven, morning star, son of the dawn!"*

KJV Rev. 22:16: *"…I Jesus… am the bright and morning star."*
NIV Rev. 22:16: *"…I, Jesus… am the bright morning star."*

By changing "Lucifer" to "Morning Star", modern versions end up giving the same title to both Satan (Isaiah 14) and Jesus (Revelation 22). That creates confusion and blurs the line between Christ and the devil.

Also, an interesting experiment to show this issue would be to ask a Christian who uses modern Bible versions, "Where does everything that you believe stem from?" They will likely tell you the Bible unreservedly. Then ask a follow up, "Who is Lucifer?" They will likely tell you it was the Devil before he fell (most anyone is familiar with this name). Then a final question, "Where did you learn that from?" They will franticly search their bibles only to their amazement that that name DOES NOT EVEN APPEAR IN THEIR BIBLES, unless… they have the King James Bible (the NJKV also includes the name). A specific belief about

a specific name of the Devil that they believe but it is not in their Bibles. This presents quite a predicament.

Also, as a side note, I wonder who would want to remove that name from your Bible? And, why? (Gen. 3)

Genesis 3:16
KJV: *"…thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee."*
ESV: *"…your desire shall be contrary to your husband, but he shall rule over you."*

The KJV says the woman's desire would be toward her husband (which many understand as a desire for closeness or dependence). The ESV flips it, saying her desire would be "contrary" to him, introducing conflict. That's not a small shift, it is completely contradictory to the King James Bible reading.

Mark 9:29
KJV: *"…by prayer and fasting."*
CSB: *"…by prayer."*

Fasting is one of the disciplines Jesus taught. Dropping it weakens the verse's teaching on spiritual warfare and the need for fasting.

Matthew 17:21

KJV: *"Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."*

NIV: Omitted.

Again, fasting is gone.

Again, who would want to remove a key verse showing you a key step in "casting out devils"? And, why? (Gen. 3)

Luke 11:2–4

KJV: *"Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name. Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done, as in heaven, so in earth. Give us day by day our daily bread. And forgive us our sins; for we also forgive every one that is indebted to us. And lead us not into temptation; but deliver us from evil."*

NASB: Shorter form, leaving out "which art in heaven," "thy will be done," and "deliver us from evil."

Jesus gave us a model prayer. Why remove so much of it?

Mark 1:2

KJV: *"As it is written in the prophets…"*

ESV: *"As it is written in Isaiah the prophet…"*

Since Mark quotes both Isaiah and Malachi, the ESV makes it look like Mark misattributed the quote. The KJV avoids the problem with "prophets."

Psalm 12:6–7

KJV: *"…The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever."*

NIV: *"…You, LORD, will keep **the needy** safe and will protect **us** forever from the wicked."*

The KJV says God is preserving **His words**. The NIV shifts it to "us" (the people). This turns a promise about God's words into a promise about protection of people. Both are true in general, but only one matches the grammar here.

Matthew 9:13 / Mark 2:17

KJV: *"…I am not come to call the righteous, but sinners to **repentance**."*

CSB: *"…I came not to call the righteous, but sinners."*

Leaving out "repentance" changes the very purpose of Christ's call. Repentance is at the heart of the gospel message, and dropping it leaves only half the truth.

Romans 8:1

KJV: *"…There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,* ***who walk not after the flesh, but after the Spirit.****"*
ESV: *"…There is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."*

The ESV cuts off the second half of the verse. The KJV keeps Paul's full thought: yes, no condemnation in Christ, but also a reminder that those in Him will walk by the Spirit, not the flesh.

Matthew 6:13 — The Lord's Prayer ending
KJV: *"…For thine is the kingdom, and the power, and the glory, for ever. Amen."*
NASB: Leaves this out; footnote only.

The ending and main thrust of the Lord's prayer, teaching us a key pattern for our prayer lives, taken out in modern versions.

Mark 10:24
KJV: *"…Children, how hard is it for them that trust in riches to enter into the kingdom of God!"*
NIV: *"…how hard it is* ***to enter the kingdom of God****!"*

The KJV makes it clear: the problem is trusting in riches. The NIV just says it's hard for anyone to enter God's kingdom. Very different.

John 7:8

KJV: *"…I go not up **yet** unto this feast…"*

ESV: *"…I am not going up to this feast…"*

In the KJV, Jesus says He is not going up "yet," which matches what happens a few verses later when He does go. The ESV makes it sound like He lied, since He says He's not going at all, then does.

Luke 4:18

KJV: *"…he hath sent me to heal the brokenhearted, to preach deliverance to the captives, and recovering of sight to the blind, to set at liberty them that are bruised."*

CSB: *"…He has sent me to proclaim release to the captives and recovery of sight to the blind, to set free the oppressed."*

The phrase "heal the brokenhearted" is dropped. That's one of Jesus' most famous descriptions of His ministry, and it's missing.

Luke 9:56

KJV: *"…For the Son of man is not come to destroy men's lives, but to save them."*
NASB: Shortened: *"…they went on to another village."*

An entire statement of Christ's saving purpose disappears.

John 3:16
KJV: *"…his only begotten Son…"*
NIV: *"…his one and only Son…"*

Removing "begotten" (which shows Christ's unique eternal relationship with the Father) weakens the verse's theology. Jesus isn't God's "only" son, Adam is called a son of God, believers are sons of God. But He is the only **begotten** Son.

Matthew 20:20
KJV: *"…the mother of Zebedee's children with her sons, worshipping him…"*
ESV: *"…the mother of the sons of Zebedee came up to him with her sons…"* ("worshipping him" omitted).

The KJV shows the disciples' family worshipping Jesus. The ESV leaves it out, lessening a worship moment.

Acts 2:30
KJV: *"…he would raise up Christ to sit on his throne."*

CSB: *"…he would **raise up one of his descendants** to sit on his throne."*

The KJV points directly to Christ. The CSB dilutes the clarity of Peter's sermon by making it sound more generic.

Acts 3:13
KJV: *"…the God of our fathers, hath glorified his Son Jesus…"*
NASB: *"…has glorified his servant Jesus…"*

The KJV says **Son**, pointing to Christ's unique status. The NASB says **servant**, which is true in a sense, but is much weaker.

Mark 9:44, 46
KJV: *"Where their worm dieth not, and the fire is not quenched."* (repeated in vv. 44, 46, 48)
NIV: These lines are omitted in vv. 44 and 46, kept only in v. 48.

Jesus repeated it three times for emphasis. Modern versions reduce it to once, softening the warning of hell in one of its most gruesome forms it is spoken of.

Revelation 1:11

KJV: *"…I am Alpha and Omega, the first and the last: and, What thou seest, write in a book…"*
ESV: *"…Write what you see in a book…"*

The strong self-identification of Christ as Alpha and Omega is cut.

Matthew 17:21 (already mentioned, but worth repeating here)
KJV: *"…Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting."*
ESV: Omitted.

That omission affects spiritual warfare teaching again.

Jude 1:25
KJV: *"…to the only wise God our Saviour…"*
ESV: *"…to the only God…"*

KJV explicitly ties God to being our **Saviour**. The ESV removes the direct reference.

Micah 5:2
KJV: *"But thou, Bethlehem Ephratah… out of thee shall he come forth unto me that is to be ruler in Israel; whose goings forth have been from of old,* ***from everlasting.***"

NIV: *"whose origins are from of old, **from ancient times.**"*

The **KJV** clearly calls Christ eternal, His "goings forth" are from **everlasting**. That points straight to His deity, showing He existed before time and will always exist. No ending and no beginning.

The **NIV** says "from ancient days," which makes it sound like He has a long history, but not necessarily eternal. That could apply to a created being.

2 Samuel 21:19

KJV: *"…Elhanan… slew the brother of Goliath…"*
ESV: *"…Elhanan… killed Goliath the Gittite…"*

If the modern versions rendering is taken at face value, it directly contradicts 1 Samuel 17, where David kills Goliath. The **KJV** translators preserved this correctly by including the Hebrew "the brother of Goliath" (compare 1 Chron. 20:5, which clarifies this). Modern bibles have David killing Goliath in 1 Samuel 17; and then Elhanan killing Goliath in 2 Sam. 21:19. This is a plain contradiction.

1 Corinthians 9:27

KJV: *"But I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection…"*
NIV: *"No, I strike a blow to my body and make it my slave.."*

In this verse, the NIV talks about self-harm and making your body into your slave. These are not biblical teachings that you would want anyone to take away from this passage. The KJV makes it clear that Paul is talking about self-control and bringing your body into your control. Vastly different from the self-harm of the NIV.

Luke 24:51 (cf. with Acts 1:1-2)
KJV: *"carried up into heaven…"*
RSV: *This verse ending is omitted in Nestle's Greek Text (text used for modern versions) and has been omitted in multiple editions of the RSV, NASV, and others.*

The issue of modern versions omitting or "footnoting" this part of the verse in Luke 24:51 is found when it is compared with Luke's other writing in Acts 1:1-2. Here he tells Theophilus how he wrote to him before (referring to the gospel of Luke) and told him all things "of all that Jesus began both to do and teach, Until the day in which he was taken up.." Luke's own statement in Acts 1:1-2 discounts any "false copy" of his original "treatise" (gospel of Luke) that does not include the ending where Jesus is "taken up". Modern versions and the Greek text on which they are based create a contradiction in their "bibles" by omitting this.

Conclusion

These aren't just stylistic differences. They touch Jesus' deity, the Trinity, His virgin birth, His saving blood, salvation by faith, the fall of man, spiritual warfare, marriage, and the authority of God's Word itself. The King James Bible preserves the stronger and clearer readings. Modern versions often dull or remove them completely.

DOCTRINAL ISSUES IN NEW BIBLE VERSIONS

☆ Baptism Before or After Salvation? (Acts 8:37)

KJV- 36 And as they went on their way, they came unto a certain water: and the eunuch said, See, here is water; what doth hinder me to be baptized?
37 ¶ And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered and said, I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.
38 ¶ And he commanded the chariot to stand still: and they went down both into the water, both Philip and the eunuch; and he baptized him.

NIV- 36 As they traveled along the road, they came to some water and the eunuch said, "Look, here is water. What can stand in the way of my being baptized?"
37 (MISSING)
38 And he gave orders to stop the chariot. Then both Philip and
the eunuch went down into the water and Philip baptized him.

☆ Was Jesus God? (Phil. 2:5-6)

KJV- Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus: Who, being in the form of God, thought it not robbery to be equal with God:

ESV- Have this mind among yourselves, which is yours in Christ Jesus, who, though he was in the form of God, did not count equality with God a thing to be grasped

☆ Is the Wife supposed to be Against her Husband? (Gen. 3:16)

KJV- Unto the woman he said, I will greatly multiply thy sorrow and thy conception; in sorrow thou shalt bring forth children; and thy desire shall be to thy husband, and he shall rule over thee.

ESV- To the woman he said, "I will surely multiply your pain in childbearing; in pain you shall bring forth children. Your desire shall be contrary to your husband, but he shall rule over you.

☆ Who is Lucifer? (Isa.14:12)

KJV- How art thou fallen from heaven, O Lucifer, son of the morning! how art thou cut down to the ground, which didst weaken the nations!

ESV- "How you are fallen from heaven, O Day Star, son of Dawn! How you are cut down to the ground, you who laid the nations low!

****No other Bible version out there mentions the name "Lucifer" even once (Except for the NKJV) in their entire Bible. The NIV goes even further down a bad path by referring to the Devil and Jesus Christ by the same name "Morning Star".

NIV- "How you have fallen from heaven, morning star, son of the dawn! You have been cast down to the earth, you who once laid low the nations!

NIV in Revelation 22:16 - "I, Jesus, have sent my angel to give youfn this testimony for the churches. I am the Root and the Offspring of David, and the bright Morning Star.

☆ Is God a Trinity (1 John 5:7)

KJV- For there are three that bear record in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one.

ESV- 7 For there are three that testify:
8 the Spirit and the water and the blood; and these three agree.

***NO MENTION OF THE TRINITY HERE AT ALL IN ANY NEW BIBLE VERSIONS

TRANSLATION PRACTICES: DYNAMIC VS. FORMAL EQUIVALENCE: WHY TRANSLATION PHILOSOPHY MATTERS

Modern translators, following the lead of **Eugene Nida** in the mid-20th century, adopted what is called *Dynamic Equivalence*[52] (sometimes "functional equivalence"). Rather than rendering the precise words of the Hebrew and Greek, this method seeks to communicate what translators believe is the "thought" behind the text, often rephrasing or reshaping verses to make them smoother for modern readers.[53]

By contrast, the King James Bible was produced under the principle of *Formal Equivalence* (often called *verbal equivalence*).[54] This approach insists on preserving the actual words and structures of the original languages, as nearly as possible, in the receptor language. The translators recognized that the Bible claims inspiration

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[52] Eugene A. Nida, *Toward a Science of Translating* (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1964). 159

[53] Eugene A. Nida, Toward a Science of Translating (Leiden: E. J. Brill, 1964), p. 166-168

[54] The Translators to the Reader (1611 Preface to the KJV), in F. H. A. Scrivener, The Authorized Edition of the English Bible (1611): Its Subsequent Reprints and Modern Representatives (Cambridge: University Press, 1884), p. 265-311

down to the very words (Matthew 4:4; Proverbs 30:5), not merely the general ideas.

The consequences of these two approaches are stark:

- **Formal/Verbal Equivalence (KJV):** Prioritizes accuracy to the inspired words, allowing the reader to study, interpret, and trust that the rendering reflects the original.
- **Dynamic Equivalence (NIV, NLT, etc.):** Prioritizes readability and cultural adaptation, but introduces the bias and theological assumptions of the translators themselves.

Dr. D.A. Waite summarized the danger well: when men depart from translating the very words of God to paraphrasing ideas, showing how man, not God, becomes the authority when dynamic equivalence is used.

> "For translation that purports to be a translation of God's Words, to add these words is **absolutely diabolical**. It is adding to the Words of God."[55]

Waite characterizes the serpent's tactics in Genesis 3 as a **dynamic-equivalence** paraphrase of God's words:

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[55] D. A. Waite, Defending the King James Bible: A Fourfold Superiority, 3rd ed. (Collingswood, NJ: The Bible For Today Press, 2006), 151

> "He used the DYNAMIC EQUIVALENCE method… That is, he made a loose paraphrase of what God's words were…"[56]

This philosophical shift explains why so many doctrinally vital verses are weakened or omitted in modern versions. It is not simply about different manuscripts, it is also about a fundamentally different **view of what the Bible is**: the very words of God, or merely a vehicle for conveying religious ideas.

[56] Waite, Defending the King James Bible, 119.

EASE OF READING

One of the most repeated objections to the King James Bible is not textual, doctrinal, or historical but practical: *"It's too hard to read."* In the age of "easy-to-understand" versions, the assumption is that 17th-century English must be inaccessible to modern readers. But when we step beyond assumption and examine the evidence, a very different conclusion emerges.

A. What the Numbers Actually Say

Readability is not a matter of personal opinion. Scholars use standardized formulas such as the **Flesch Reading Ease Score** and **Flesch–Kincaid Grade Level** to evaluate text difficulty. These measure average sentence length and syllables per word.

- The KJV consistently scores at or around an **8th-grade reading level**. For example, Genesis 1 scores 8.13 (8th grade), Romans 3:1–23 scores 5.63 (6th grade), and Romans 8 scores 7.72 (8th grade) .
- Peer-reviewed research by Emilio Matricciani (2023) on Matthew's Gospel translations placed the **KJV at ~8 years of schooling for "easy"**

reading, compared with >13 for the NASB and ~6 for the NIV, squarely in the middle of the field.[57]

In other words: the KJV is not the hardest English Bible, and by some measures it is easier than many modern versions.

B. Archaic Words: A Help, Not a Hindrance

The most common complaint is about words like *thee, thou, ye, thine*. Critics assume these are outdated formalities. In reality, they preserve a distinction between **singular** and **plural** that modern English has lost.

- *Thou/thee/thy* = singular.
- *Ye/you/your* = plural.

This provides clarity. When Jesus said in Luke 22:31–32, "Satan hath desired to have **you** (all the disciples), but I have prayed for **thee** (Peter)," the KJV makes the switch explicit.[58] Modern versions flatten both to "you," obscuring the point.

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[57] Emilio Matricciani, "Readability across Time and Languages: The Case of Matthew's Gospel Translations," *AppliedMath* 3, no. 2 (2023): 497–509.

[58] Oxford English Dictionary, s.v. "thou, pron.," OED Online (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2023).

Far from making the text less clear, the KJV often makes it **more precise**.

C. Designed for Oral Clarity

Literary historians emphasize that the King James Bible was **crafted for the ear** as much as for the eye. Its cadence, parallelism, and rhythm were designed to be read aloud in church.

- **Gordon Campbell (Oxford)** argues that the KJV's formal idiom is **not opaque but rhetorical**, intentionally suited for public proclamation.[59]
- **Leland Ryken (Wheaton)** defends the KJV's formal style as an aid to clarity, not an obstacle, insisting that its archaisms are minimal and its diction memorably concrete.[60]
- **David Norton (Cambridge)** notes that while the KJV preserves an elevated register, it has remained **functionally intelligible** for centuries.[61]

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[59] Gordon Campbell, *Bible: The Story of the King James Version, 1611–2011* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 127–128.

[60] Leland Ryken, "Ten Fallacies about the King James Version," *Southern Baptist Journal of Theology* 15, no. 4 (2011): 4–17.

[61] David Norton, *A Textual History of the King James Bible* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2005), 14–15.

When read aloud, the KJV proves remarkably accessible, which explains its enduring role in worship and evangelism.

D. Readability ≠ Shallowness

Modern claims of "easier reading" often confuse **simplification** with **comprehension**. The Bible was never meant to read like a comic book. It was meant to challenge, to lodge in memory, and to be studied.

- Psalm 119:130 — "The entrance of thy words giveth light; it giveth understanding unto the simple."
- Proverbs 2:4–5 — understanding comes by searching "as for hid treasures."

The KJV does not obscure truth with jargon. Its plain Anglo-Saxon vocabulary (*sin, blood, law, grace*) is simple. Its cadence and dignity, however, call the reader to seriousness. This balance is one reason it has been memorized by children, preached by evangelists, and used by missionaries for centuries .

E. Historical Reality: Ordinary People Read It

The claim that the KJV is "too hard" ignores history. For four centuries it was the **common man's Bible**: plowboys

memorized it, mothers taught it, coal miners sang from it, and revivalists preached it across nations.

- **David Crystal (Oxford)** documents in *Begat* that hundreds of KJV phrases entered everyday English precisely because ordinary people grasped and repeated them.[62]
- The great missionary movements of Carey, Judson, and Taylor were carried forward not by "simplified" Bibles but by translations rooted in the KJV's textual line .

If it were truly unreadable, it could not have functioned as the people's Bible for so long.

F. Scholarly Consensus: Its "Difficulty" Is Overstated

Across the academic spectrum, scholars acknowledge that while the KJV contains some archaisms, it remains accessible and valuable:

- **Ryken**: Its "formality is a virtue, not a vice" in sacred literature.
- **Campbell**: Its idiom is elevated but clear when read aloud.

[62] David Crystal, *Begat: The King James Bible and the English Language* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010).

- **Norton**: Its reception history proves its functional intelligibility.
- **Crystal**: Its phrasing shaped English because people understood it.

Even critical voices admit that readability complaints are exaggerated.

G. Conclusion

When the evidence is weighed, the charge that the KJV is "too difficult" collapses.

1. **Objective studies** show the KJV's readability is at or below that of many modern versions.
2. Its so-called "archaic" forms often **clarify** meaning rather than obscure it.
3. It was designed for **oral clarity**, and scholars affirm its continued intelligibility.
4. History demonstrates that it functioned as the Bible of the people for 400 years.

The King James Bible is not harder, it is **sharper, clearer, and more enduring**. Its dignity does not hinder comprehension; it elevates it. As Psalm 19:7 says: *"The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple."*

MAJOR FAQ'S

When it comes to the King James Bible issue, certain objections appear again and again. Many of these are less about evidence and more about assumptions, but they deserve careful answers. Below are some of the most common questions, along with responses grounded in Scripture, history, and the record of scholarship.

Q1. "How can the King James Bible be the standard, when it's just one translation among many?"

This is often the first objection raised. But the question misses a key point: every generation must have a standard. Remember, this position we have posed is "faith based". It is not a blind faith, it BEGINS with faith and finds the answers from there.

- Psalm 12:6–7 — God promised to preserve His words, not just their "general message."
- Matthew 24:35 — Christ said His words would not pass away.
- 1 Peter 1:23, 25 — The Word of God "liveth and abideth for ever."

Somewhere in history, God must have preserved His Word in a form His people could use. The King James Bible became that standard in the English-speaking world for over 275 years. Missionaries, pastors, and ordinary believers measured all other translations by it. Even today, new versions constantly compare themselves against the KJV, not against each other.

Q2. "Didn't the translators themselves admit it wasn't perfect?"

It is true that the KJV translators, in their preface, acknowledged that even the "meanest [worst] translation" of the Bible could still be called the Word of God. But this humility does not undermine the providential perfection of their work.

God has often used men who did not fully grasp the scope of His plan. Jeremiah's scribes may not have realized they were producing Scripture (Jer. 36), but God declared it so. Similarly, the KJV translators were instruments in God's preservation work whether or not they foresaw its enduring role.

A Note About The KJV Translators Methods

Roughly **fifty-four** scholars were appointed, organized into **six companies** at Westminster, Cambridge, and Oxford. Each company had a defined portion:

– **First Westminster** (Gen–2 Kgs), **First Cambridge** (1 Chr–Song), **First Oxford** (Isa–Mal), **Second Cambridge** (Apocrypha), **Second Oxford** (Gospels–Acts–Rev), **Second Westminster** (Romans–Jude).[63]

They followed **15 translation rules** (issued by Bancroft)[64], including: use the **Bishops' Bible** as the base but correct it "where it deviates from the truth of the original," **retain ecclesiastical terms** (e.g., "church," not "congregation"), and **consult earlier English Bibles** (Tyndale, Coverdale, Matthew, Great Bible, Geneva) wherever they helped. The process ran in **stages**: first, each translator worked independently; then **company sessions** compared and reconciled; finally, a **general reviewing committee** (a small group drawn from all companies) harmonized the whole. **Marginal notes** were added sparingly, **not** to subvert authority but to acknowledge transparent alternatives in places of legitimate ambiguity. The end result is a Bible that is **textually careful** and **honest**, and whose English favors **short, concrete Anglo-Saxon**

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[63] Ward Allen, *Translating for King James: Notes Made by a Translator of King James's Bible* (Nashville: Vanderbilt University Press, 1969), 28–35.

[64] These rules are historically documented and available in multiple sources. For a discussion, see Alister E. McGrath, *In the Beginning: The Story of the King James Bible and How It Changed a Nation, a Language, and a Culture* (New York: Anchor Books, 2002), 174–178.

diction, deliberately chosen to lodge in the ear and memory of ordinary hearers.

The ~14 passes each passage endured

1. Every translator in a company first translated the same assigned chapters independently.
2. The company met to compare, debate, and agree on its text.
3. When a book was finished by one company, it was **sent to the other companies** for serious review.
4. Unresolved differences were **escalated to a general meeting** of senior revisers drawn from all companies, who produced the final harmonized text.

In practice, this yielded roughly **fourteen examinations** of each passage before press, far beyond the workflow of modern versions.

The Fifteen Rules that governed the whole work (1604)

1. **Bishops' Bible as the base**, altered only where the truth of the originals required it.
2. **Proper names** to be kept as commonly used.
3. **Ecclesiastical terms** retained (e.g., "church," not "congregation").
4. Where a word has several senses, keep the one most used by the ancient fathers, fitting the place and the analogy of faith.

5. **Chapter divisions** not to be changed (or only minimally, if necessary).
6. **No doctrinal marginal notes**; margins only to explain Hebrew/Greek words that cannot be briefly expressed in the text.
7. **Cross-references** placed in the margins as helpful.
8. **Each man to translate the same chapters privately**; then meet, confer, and agree on what shall stand.
9. When a company finishes a book, **send it to the rest** to be considered seriously and judiciously.
10. If companies **differ**, send reasons and notes; if not resolved, **compound the difference at the general meeting** of chief persons at the end.
11. For **hard places**, write to any learned man in the realm for judgment.
12. **Bishops** to notify their clergy, urging the learned to send observations to the companies at Westminster, Cambridge, or Oxford.
13. **Directors** in each company: the Dean(s) (Westminster/Chester) and the King's Hebrew/Greek Professors in each university.
14. Earlier English versions to be **used wherever they agree better with the text** than the Bishops' (Tyndale, Matthew, Coverdale, Great Bible/Whitchurch, Geneva).

Besides the directors, **three or four ancient and grave divines** in each university (not otherwise employed) to act

as **overseers** of the Hebrew and Greek, to secure careful observance of Rule 4.

THE SUPERIOR TRANSLATORS OF THE KJV

Lancelot Andrews



-During his 1-2 month vacations with his family, he would find a master of a language he did not know and learn the language before returning home
-He studied Oriental languages and Divinity at Cambridge
-He became the lecturer of Divinity at Cambridge
-At 24 he became the Master at Pembroke Hall
-He left the college to be the chaplain in ordinary to Queen Elizabeth, and then later he would become the Dean of Westminster
-Concerning his translation work, his work was the best among the others in his company
-He wrote all his personal devotions in Greek
-It was said of him that he was so skilled and versatile in languages that if he was present during the tower of Babel he could have served as interpreter general

John Bois



-At 5 yrs old he read through the Hebrew Bible
-At 6 yrs old he was able to write the Greek language in a "fair and elegant manner"
-At 15 yrs old he was enrolled at St. John's College in Cambridge, and at the halfway mark of his first year he was writing letters in Greek to his Masters
-While studying under one of his Masters, he had read through 12 Greek authors in verse and prose in the most difficult dialects and phrases that could be found
-It was common for him to go to the library at 4am and stay until 8pm
-At old age he still studied for 8 hours a day, reading and correcting ancient authors
-He would preach without notes because he wanted to be heard and understood by the most humble and ignorant hearers

Henry Savile



-He was educated at Brazen Nose College in Oxford, and then soon after travelled to France to perfect himself in literature
-His specialty was Greek and Math, and he would end up becoming the tutor of these subjects to Queen Elizabeth; his tutoring was so successful that her study habits were clearly seen into her old age
-He was the first person to completely translate the entire work of Chrysostom (8 huge folios); he translated many works into Latin and English
-He served as the Warden of Merton College, Provost of Eton College

***These are just a few of the 54 outstandingly qualified translators of the KJV

THE SUPERIOR TRANSLATION METHODS OF THE KJV

1. The basic text shall be that of the Bishop's Bible, with as little altered as the truth of the original will permit.
2. People's names, including those of the authors of Biblical books, shall be retained in the ordinary spelling as far as might be.
3. The old ecclesiastical words shall be retained (ex: "church").
4. Words of more than one meaning shall be used in the sense found in most of the ancient fathers, appropriate to the context and consistent with the analogy of the faith (In addition, to avoid any formalistic, stilted literary style, a variety of English words were used to render the same Hebrew or Greek word).
5. The chapter divisions shall follow those of the Bishop's Bible.
6. No marginal notes shall be added, except for the explanation of the Hebrew or Greek words which cannot be briefly and fitly expressed in the text.
7. Cross-references shall only relate to the relevant passages elsewhere in Scripture.
8. Translations and revisions were to be done first by individual then submitted to the whole company for scrutiny, criticism, and final approval.
9. As each section of Books are completed, they shall be submitted to the other companies, "to be considered of seriously and judiciously, for his Majesty is very careful in this point."
10. If any company, upon reviewing a Book, doubt or differ upon any place, they shall notify the original company. If their objection is declined, the matter shall be settled at a general meeting.
11. In cases of special obscurity the translators shall be entitled to request assistance form any learned man in the land.
12. Each bishop shall seek the judgment of those among his clergy who are "skillful in tongues" upon the work at hand.
13. The directors of each company shall be Deans of Westminster and Chester, and the Regius Professors of Oxford and Cambridge universities.
14. The following translations shall be used when they agree better with the text than the Bishop's Bible - Tyndale, Coverdale, Matthew, the Great Bible, and the Geneva Bible.
15. Three or four of the most ancient and grave divines, from either of the universities and not employed in the translating, shall be overseers of the work.

THE UNIQUENESS OF THE KJV

- It was authorized by a King (1 Peter 2:17; Ecc. 8:4)
- No Copyright (2 Tim. 2:9)
- Scientific (Lev. 15:13; Job 25:5 37:7; 38:19; Ps. 75:5; 119:70)
- Use of Italics (The only honest translation because it marks all connective language additions needed when making any translation.)
- Self Defining (Mt. 10:1-5; Gen. 8:1-5; 17:10-11; Judges 9:24, 56; 2 Samuel 12:3
- The time in history of its translation (A major, yet often dismissed, factor concerning the KJV is the timeinhistorywhenitwastranslated. Therearemanyschoolsof thought today that deeply effect our mindset concerning life's issues. These schools of thought affect us every day and cause different outcomes to take place in a plethora of circumstances and situations. For example: Atheism, Rationalism and Deism effect the decisions our government and business leaders make concerning a whole host of issues (abortion, homosexuality, prayer in schools, domestic laws, availability of anti-biblical products, etc.). At the time of the writing of the King James Bible none of these things were established arenas of thinking. French Atheism was not in vogue, German Rationalists did not exist, therefore had no influence on anyones thinking. English Deism was not around so no one thought that God was "dead" or absent from his creation. Thus men could produce a Bible that without objection, a Bible that could be believed by the common man!
- The preeminence it gives to the Lord Jesus Christ: Verses kept intact- Jo. 1:18; Lk. 2:33; 1 Ti. 3:16; Acts 4:27; 8:37; 1 Jo. 5:7 (to name a few)
- Signs and Maps (The use of key words and phrases and other built-in study tools)-
  - -That Day/The Day of the Lord-
  - -Those Days -
  - -Serpent; Beast; Dragon -
  - -Sword -
  - -Selah -
  - -Third Day / Three Days -
  - -The use of Numerology -
  - -The law of First Mention -
  - -The use of Repetition -
  - -Self-defining / Built-in Dictionary



- The geographic location from whence it came- England is the standard for world time and direction
- The fruit it has borne-
  - Greatest time in world missions
  - More folks get saved under its preaching; more sustained growth is measured
  - The fear it creates
  - The enemies it has made and the controversy always surrounding it (like none other)
  - Its popularity

Q3. "Isn't the language too archaic for modern readers?"

This has already been addressed at length in the previous chapter. The evidence shows the KJV is written at an 8th-grade level on average, often easier than modern versions. Its so-called "archaic" pronouns actually add precision, and its rhythm aids comprehension.

Far from being inaccessible, history proves it was the Bible of plowboys, sailors, and mothers teaching their children.

Q4. "What about the errors in the KJV? Doesn't it contradict itself?"

Critics often point to numerical differences (e.g., Ahaziah's age in 2 Kings 8:26 vs. 2 Chronicles 22:2; Jehoiachin's age in 2 Kings 24:8 vs. 2 Chronicles 36:9). These supposed "errors" have reasonable explanations:

- In ancient monarchies, sons often began to reign under their fathers before taking full kingship. Thus different numbers can refer to different phases of reign.
- Numbers 25:9 lists 24,000 deaths; 1 Corinthians 10:8 says 23,000. The difference is easily explained: 23,000 in a single day, 24,000 total.

These are not contradictions but only “apparent” contradictions. They do not hold up once further investigation is done.

Q5. “Didn’t the original 1611 KJV include the Apocrypha?”

Yes, the 1611 edition contained a section labeled “The Books Called Apocrypha”, but crucially, they were not intermingled with the Old and New Testaments. They were set apart between Malachi and Matthew, and never treated as canonical.

By contrast, Alexandrian manuscripts such as Vaticanus and Sinaiticus do include the Apocrypha mixed in with Scripture. Origen’s Hexapla did the same. The KJV translators followed the historic Protestant practice: including Apocrypha for historical reference but marking it as non-Scriptural.

Q6. “Haven’t there been many revisions? Which KJV is perfect?”

This objection plays on confusion between revisions and editions.

- The differences between the 1611 and modern KJV are mostly spelling and typography (e.g., sonne →

son, musick → music, the “long s” that looked like “f”).

- A few printing errors were corrected (e.g., the infamous “Wicked Bible” of 1631 that accidentally omitted “not” from “Thou shalt not commit adultery”).
- No doctrinal or substantive changes were made.

Thus, when critics claim “thousands of changes,” they inflate minor printing updates. The KJV today is the same Bible as 1611, with spelling modernized.

Q7. “Isn’t it divisive to insist on the KJV? Shouldn’t we focus on unity and love?”

Unity must be built on truth. If the Bible is our foundation, then the question of which Bible is not “minor.” The Apostle Paul warned that false teachers would “corrupt the word of God” (2 Cor. 2:17). To dismiss the issue as irrelevant is to dismiss the very source of doctrine, reproof, correction, and instruction (2 Tim. 3:16).

The KJV debate only feels divisive because it forces us to ask: Has God kept His promise to preserve His words? If He has, then there must be a standard text. If He has not, then all unity is built on shifting sand.

Q8. "What about people in other languages? Did God only preserve His Word in English?"

This question mixes together **two different issues**: the issues of:

1. Gods preserved/purified/perfect word that we can find and hold
2. Reliable translations

First, Gods preserved/purified/perfect word. God promised to keep His words pure forever (Psalm 12:6–7). That promise applies to the Hebrew Old Testament and the Greek New Testament, faithfully preserved in the Masoretic Text and the Textus Receptus, all the way through to the English KJV. This is the promised word we can hold today, 100% perfect.

Second, Reliable translations. When translators **faithfully** use and translate from those preserved/pure texts from Antioch, the Jewish Masoretic Text, or the KJV, people around the world can read the true Word of God in their own tongue. These Bibles are not corrupt; they give God's Word accurately and faithfully. They are reliable translations, not corruptions.

But, Why English?

That touches on another topic for another book, but consider this: English has become the universal language of the modern world. It is the language of commerce, technology, diplomacy, and missions. More missionaries carry English Bibles than any other. English is the language of the end times. It makes sense, then, that God would bring His purified Word into the language that would be universal.

So here's the bottom line:

- In many languages today, we have **reliable, accurate, not-corrupt Bibles** when they are translated from the preserved Hebrew and Greek and KJV.
- But in English, God has given us the **purified Bible**, His words refined and perfected in the King James Bible.

This isn't "English-only salvation." It is simply recognizing that God made a promise to preserve His words and to purify them, and that promise found its final home in the English KJV.

Q9. "Aren't today's scholars better equipped than those in 1611?"

The KJV translators were among the most skilled linguists ever assembled. Many spoke 8–15 languages fluently.

They had access to all the major manuscripts in existence at the time, including those still used today. They worked in teams, cross-checking one another's work in ways modern committees rarely match.

Modern technology has given us searchable databases, but truth is not found in computers, it is found in the words God preserved. The translators of 1611 were not hindered by lack of technology; they were aided by unparalleled scholarship and divine providence.

Q10. "If the KJV is perfect, why not call it inspired?"

We do not say the KJV was newly inspired in 1611. We say it is preserved and purified providentially by God. Just as God told Jeremiah to rewrite His words after Jehoiakim destroyed the original scroll (Jer. 36), even adding "many like words," so God has preserved and purified His Word through history. Inspiration is the initial giving; preservation is the keeping and purifying.

The KJV is the fruit of God's promise to keep His words pure for every generation (Ps. 12:6–7).

Q11. "Did Erasmus 'add' the Johannine Comma (1 John 5:7–8) to please critics? Isn't it late?"

The claim: Erasmus supposedly "gave in" and inserted *"in heaven, the Father, the Word, and the Holy Ghost: and these three are one"* only after pressure, and the wording is "late."

The record with dates: the Comma existed in the church's text and preaching long **before** Erasmus, especially in the Latin West. Greek copies that carry it are late but **not** non-existent. The early church quotes it over a thousand years before modern versions tell you it "showed up". The "Erasmus promise" story is a modern myth.

Greek manuscript trail

- **GA 629 (Ottobonianus)** — the **earliest Greek MS with the Comma in the main text**, dated **A.D. 1362–1363** (14th century).
- **GA 61 (Codex Montfortianus)** — Greek minuscule, **c. 1520** (early 16th century), includes the Comma in-text.
- **GA 918** — Greek minuscule, text of the Comma copied **in the 1570s** (third-oldest Greek MS with the Comma in-text).

Margins / lectionary-type evidence (dated notes):

- **GA 221** — 10th-century manuscript; a Comma note was **added in the margin after 1854** (we know this because an 1854 description didn't list it).

- **GA 177** — 10th century manuscript; a Comma note was written **no earlier than the 1770s** by **Ignatius Hardt (b. 1749)**.

Latin manuscript & patristic trail

- **Priscillian of Ávila (d. c. 385)**[65] — earliest explicit citation of the "heavenly witnesses"
- **Cyprian (200–258 A.D.)** referenced the Trinity of 1 John 5:7 (*"and these three are one"*).[66]
- **Council of Carthage (North Africa), A.D. 484** [67]
- **Fulgentius of Ruspe (A.D. 527)** — cites the Comma in anti-Arian works (e.g., *Contra Arianos*).
- **Cassiodorus (c. 500s)** — cites/uses the Comma in the Latin tradition.
- **Old Latin / early Vulgate stream (5th–7th c.)** — earliest **Latin MSS** with the Comma are from **5th–7th centuries** (e.g., Freisinger fragment; León palimpsest).

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[65] Priscillian, Liber Apologeticus 1.4, in The Works of Priscillian of Avila, trans. Marco Conti (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2010), 36.

[66] In his treatise *On the Unity of the Church*, Cyprian writes, "The Lord says, 'I and the Father are one'; and again it is written of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit, 'And these three are one.'" Cyprian, *De Unitate Ecclesiae*, 6. This is considered by many to be the earliest clear reference to the *Comma Johanneum*.

[67] Victor of Vita, Historia Persecutionis Africanae Provinciae [History of the Persecution of the African Province], 3.11, in Victor Vitensis: Historia Persecutionis, ed. and trans. John Moorhead (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1992), 78–79. (Council of Carthage, A.D. 484, citing the Comma).

Early printed editions (with dates)

- **Complutensian Polyglot (Spain)** — **Greek NT printed in 1514**, papal sanction **1520**, **released 1522**; included the Comma in its apparatus/edition (part of Stunica's team's text). This shows the Comma in print **before** Erasmus's 3rd edition was on the market.

The "Erasmus promise" myth

Reputable scholarship (Henk Jan de Jonge)[68] shows no evidence Erasmus ever vowed to insert the Comma if shown a Greek MS; the story is a later legend repeated by Metzger and others.[69]

Q12. "Is the Longer Ending of Mark (16:9–20) a later addition?"

The claim: Critics argue that Mark's Gospel originally ended at 16:8, and that verses 9–20 were a later church addition.

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[68] Henk Jan de Jonge, "Erasmus and the Comma Johanneum," *Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses* 56 (1980): 381-389. De Jonge demonstrates the story is a legend that originated with Edward Gibbon and was later repeated uncritically.

[69] Bruce M. Metzger, The Text of the New Testament: Its Transmission, Corruption, and Restoration, 4th ed. (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2005), 101–2. (for the basic Greek MS listing: GA 629, GA 61, GA 918).

The record with dates: The longer ending is present in the vast majority of manuscripts, quoted by fathers centuries before the two "oldest" codices (א, B) that omit it. The church has used these verses for nearly two millennia.

Greek manuscript trail

- **Codex Vaticanus (B)** — ends at Mark 16:8, c. A.D. 325–350.
- **Codex Sinaiticus (א)** — also stops at 16:8, c. A.D. 330–360.
- **Majority of MSS** — over 1,600 Greek manuscripts include Mark 16:9–20, from the 5th century onward.

Patristic trail

- **Irenaeus (c. 180)** — quotes Mark 16:19 ("received up into heaven, and sitteth on the right hand of God") in Against Heresies (3.10.5).[70] This proves the longer ending was known in the 2nd century, long before Vaticanus and Sinaiticus.
- **Tatian (c. 170)** — in the Diatessaron (a gospel harmony), includes Mark 16:9–20.
- **Hippolytus (c. 200–235)** — refers to Mark 16:18 ("they shall lay hands on the sick, and they shall recover").

[70] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.10.5, in *Ante-Nicene Fathers*, vol. 1, ed. Alexander Roberts and James Donaldson (Peabody, MA: Hendrickson, 1994), 426.

- **Augustine (d. 430)** — defended the passage as authentic and used it in teaching.

Early versions

- **Old Latin (2nd–3rd c.)** — contains the longer ending.
- **Vulgate (Jerome, c. 400**) — includes the longer ending.
- **Syriac Peshitta (c. 150–200**) — also includes the longer ending.

The longer ending was:

- Quoted in the 2nd century, disproving the idea of a "late" addition.
- Received in all major branches of the church (Latin, Syriac, Greek Byzantine).
- Used for centuries, carrying the resurrection appearances and Great Commission.

Q14. "Why does the KJV have Acts 8:37 (the eunuch's confession) when many modern versions omit it?"

The claim: Acts 8:37 ("And Philip said, If thou believest with all thine heart, thou mayest. And he answered… I believe that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.") is not in most early Greek manuscripts, so modern versions drop it or footnote it.

The record with dates: While early Greek witnesses are thin, the confession is well attested in Latin tradition and church usage, showing it was part of early record.

Greek manuscript trail

- Absent in early Greek uncials (א, A, B, C).
- Present in later MSS: **Codex Laudianus (E, 6th century**)[71], and several minuscules from the Middle Ages.

Versions and patristic trail

- **Old Latin (2nd–3rd c.)** — includes Acts 8:37.
- **Vulgate (Jerome, 4th–5th c**.) — preserves it.
- **Irenaeus (c. 180**) — alludes to the eunuch's confession, though not verbatim.
- **Cyprian of Carthage (c. 250**) — cites the verse explicitly in De Unitate Ecclesiae (Section 12), using the eunuch's confession as a model for baptism.[72]

[71] Codex Laudianus (E, 6th c.) in Metzger, The Text of the New Testament, 104.

[72] Cyprian, De Unitate Ecclesiae 12, in Cyprian of Carthage: The Unity of the Catholic Church, trans. Maurice Bévenot (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1971), 69.

Thus, it's not "late", it's ancient, embedded in the church's faith and practice, preserved in the Bibles that carried Christianity through the centuries.

Q16. "Didn't Erasmus insert commentary or back-translate into Revelation? Doesn't that prove corruption in the Textus Receptus and the KJV?"

Manuscript and Historical Evidence

When Erasmus compiled his first Greek New Testament (1516), he had only one Greek manuscript of Revelation (Codex 1r), and it was missing the last six verses[73] (Rev. 22:16–21). To complete the text, Erasmus translated these verses back into Greek from the Latin Vulgate.[74] Critics argue this was a serious flaw that "tainted" the Textus Receptus.

- The phrases he produced were **not doctrinally errant**. For example, "book of life" (Rev. 22:19) instead of "tree of life" aligns with multiple other passages (Rev. 20:12, 20:15).

[73] Jan Krans, "Erasmus and the Text of Revelation 22:19," *TC: A Journal of Biblical Textual Criticism* 15 (2010): 1–17.

[74] This historical event is well-documented in histories of the New Testament text. See S. P. Tregelles, *An Account of the Printed Text of the Greek New Testament* (London: Samuel Bagster and Sons, 1854), 22–23.

- Later manuscript discoveries confirmed that several of Erasmus' renderings had Greek support after all. In other words, his supposed "inventions" were vindicated by evidence unknown to him at the time.
- The charge that Erasmus "added his own commentary" is exaggerated. He did not write his own thoughts into Revelation; he supplied the missing Greek with material already in the Latin biblical tradition, which had long been received by the church.

The Faith-Based Purification Perspective

From a faith-based perspective, this event is not proof of corruption but an example of God's providential **purification of Scripture**:

1. **God allowed a gap** (the missing Greek verses), just as He allowed Jehoiakim to burn Jeremiah's scroll (Jer. 36).
2. **God overruled man's lack** by leading Erasmus to restore the words, drawing on the Latin witness.
3. **God confirmed those words** by allowing them to be carried forward, purified, and canonized in the line that produced the King James Bible.

The **warning in Revelation 22:19** ("God shall take away his part out of the book of life") takes on prophetic weight here: is it coincidence that the very passage warning

against tampering with God's words was providentially preserved, even through Erasmus' hand, at the close of the canon?

The faith-based answer is no: God superintended Erasmus' work so that His words would not fail. What critics label "an error that stuck," believers recognize as **purification**.

Q18. Why does the KJV say "Easter" in Acts 12:4? Isn't that a mistake?

Not at all. This is actually one of those places where the King James translators showed real discernment. The Greek word *pascha* can mean "Passover," but it can also mean the larger festival season that followed. Verse 3 has already told us "then were the days of unleavened bread," which means the Jewish Passover had already happened. If you try to force "Passover" into verse 4, it makes no sense, Herod would be planning Peter's execution *after* a feast that was already over. This places a flat-out contradiction into modern versions that use "Passover" here instead of Easter.

On top of that, remember who we're dealing with: **Herod was a pagan king.** He wasn't a God-fearing Jew who cared about honoring Passover. He would have no reason to arrange his schedule around a Jewish holy day. What

he *would* have cared about was avoiding trouble with the crowds during a major festival period. At that time, the spring festival season was commonly called “Easter” in English. That word referred to the broader pagan holiday season that overlapped with the Jewish calendar.

The King James translators used “Easter” here to show exactly that, Herod wasn’t waiting for a Jewish feast to end, but for the whole pagan festival season to pass before bringing Peter out. That way he could avoid a riot and still look like he was acting decisively.

So rather than being an error, “Easter” in Acts 12:4 is the **precise word choice**. It reflects both the context (the Jewish Passover had already passed) and the character of Herod (an “Edomite” by ancestry but a pagan ruler by practice who would think in terms of pagan holidays, not Jewish ones). Modern versions that change it to “Passover” actually create a contradiction and miss the historical situation Luke is describing.

Q19. Why does the KJV use *italicized* words?

When you see *italicized* words in the KJV, the translators aren’t sneaking in doctrine, they’re being up-front with you. Biblical Hebrew and Greek often leave out little words that English requires for a smooth, grammatical sentence (think of the linking verb “is,” a supplied subject, or a helper like

"there is/are"). To make the English read naturally **without** changing the meaning, the KJV team supplied those necessary words and then **flagged them in italics** so you can see exactly what was added for clear English.

Keep these four points in mind:

- **What italics do mean:** a word has been **supplied** in English because the sense is implied in the original languages.
- **What italics do not mean:** they are **not** signals of doubt, error, or guesswork. The translators are simply showing their work.
- **Other Bibles do this too:** every translation supplies words to make good English. Most modern versions just don't mark them.

Q20. Erasmus, Codex Vaticanus, and the King James Translators

Part 1. Did Erasmus ever see or use Codex Vaticanus?

Erasmus never handled Codex Vaticanus himself, but he was not ignorant of it. During the heat of the controversy over **1 John 5:7–8**, the famous *Comma Johanneum*, he wrote to friends in Rome asking whether that verse appeared in the Vatican manuscript. The Vatican librarian, **Paulus Bombasius**, answered him in a letter dated June 18, 1521. In that reply Bombasius copied out the verses

from **1 John 4–5** straight from Vaticanus, and the passage confirmed that the words defending the Trinity were not present in that manuscript.[75]

More than a decade later, in **1533**, the Spanish scholar **Juan Ginés de Sepúlveda** wrote Erasmus from Rome and sent him a lengthy report of variant readings drawn from the Vatican codex. The letter supposedly contained hundreds of places where Vaticanus differed from Erasmus's printed Greek text.[76] Even apart from correspondence, Erasmus shows in his own **Annotations** that he knew Vaticanus existed and that he sometimes checked its readings. A good example appears in his notes on **Acts 27:16**, where he refers directly to "the Vatican manuscript" and records its reading of *Cauda* instead of the more familiar *Clauda*.[77]

So while Erasmus never possessed a full copy of Vaticanus, the evidence is clear: he knew of the manuscript, he requested and received its readings, and in

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[75] Samuel Prideaux Tregelles, An Account of the Printed Text of the Greek New Testament: With Remarks on Its Revision upon Critical Principles (London: Samuel Bagster, 1854), 22.

[76] Frederic G. Kenyon, Our Bible and the Ancient Manuscripts: Being a History of the Text and Its Translations, 4th ed. (London: Eyre and Spottiswoode, 1895), 133.

[77] Desiderius Erasmus, Erasmus' Annotations on the New Testament: Acts–Romans–I and II Corinthians, ed. Anne Reeve and M. A. Screech (Leiden: Brill, 1990), 931.

at least one place he cited it by name in his own published notes.

Part 2. Did Erasmus deliberately reject the readings of Vaticanus?

Erasmus often knew about Vaticanus readings, but he almost always left them aside. He had only a few manuscripts in Basel at his disposal when he produced his editions, and those manuscripts belonged to the Byzantine tradition. When Vaticanus disagreed with the bulk of evidence he could see, Erasmus considered it untrustworthy. In fact, he even complained that Vaticanus seemed to have been influenced too heavily by the Latin tradition, which to him made it suspicious.[78]

The note on **Acts 27:16** illustrates his approach. He faithfully reports that Vaticanus reads *Cauda*, but he did not change his printed text. The same pattern appears elsewhere. Even when he was shown a long list of differences in 1533, he did not alter the foundation of his text. It wasn't ignorance, and it wasn't laziness, it was a conscious judgment call. Erasmus believed the manuscripts in his hands represented the text of the New

[78] F. H. A. Scrivener, A Plain Introduction to the Criticism of the New Testament, vol. 1, 4th ed. (London: George Bell and Sons, 1894), 119–120.

Testament more accurately than a single manuscript in Rome, no matter how ancient it might have been.

In the end, his editions became the backbone of what was later called the **Textus Receptus**. That text, in turn, was the foundation that guided the English translators in 1611.

Part 3. Did the King James translators have access to Vaticanus or Sinaiticus?

The short answer is yes and no. **Codex Sinaiticus** was not discovered until the 1800s by Tischendorf, so it had no influence on the King James Bible at all.

Codex Vaticanus is a more complicated story. Direct access to the manuscript itself was extremely limited in the early seventeenth century, and no team in England had the ability to sit down with the actual codex in the Vatican Library. However, the translators did encounter Vaticanus in two important ways.

First, they worked with the best printed Greek editions of their day, especially those of Beza. Beza's editions occasionally mention variant readings taken from older manuscripts, including Vaticanus, even when he refused to put them into the text. Through Beza's notes, the English translators would have been aware that Vaticanus

sometimes supported different readings from those in the Textus Receptus.

Second, and even more directly, the Old Testament translators used the **Sixtine Septuagint of 1587**. This was the official Roman Catholic edition of the Greek Old Testament, and it was based almost entirely on Codex Vaticanus.[79] We know from the notes of **John Bois**, one of the KJV translators, that he worked carefully through this printed LXX while revising the Apocrypha.[80] That means, at least on the Old Testament side, the King James translators held a Vaticanus-based text in their hands and made use of it during their work.

So, while the translators did not sit with Codex Vaticanus open on the table, they were not strangers to it either. They knew its readings through the printed editions they relied upon, and in the Old Testament they worked directly from a published text drawn straight from Vaticanus. Their decision to rest on the Hebrew text in the Old Testament and the Received Text in the New Testament was not

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[79] Henry Barclay Swete, An Introduction to the Old Testament in Greek: Additional Notes (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1900), 116–117, 172–174.

[80] Nicholas J. S. Hardy, "Revising the King James Apocrypha: John Bois, Isaac Casaubon, and the Case of 1 Esdras," in Labourers in the Vineyard of the Lord: Erudition and the Making of the King James Version of the Bible, ed. Mordechai Feingold, Thomas E. Levere, and Nancy Siraisi (Leiden: Brill, 2018), 266–327.

because they had never heard of Vaticanus, but because they believed the texts they chose represented the Bible more faithfully and more securely than the alternatives.

CONCLUSION: THE WORD OF GOD ENDURETH FOREVER

Every controversy in church history ultimately returns to the question of authority. *By what standard do we measure truth?* In our generation, the battle over Bible versions is no different. On the surface it appears to be a debate about manuscripts, translations, and readability. But beneath all of that lies the fundamental issue: *Has God kept His promise to preserve His words?*

From the very beginning, the serpent's question has been the same: *"Yea, hath God said?"* (Gen. 3:1). The war on words did not begin in Alexandria, nor in the Reformation, nor in the nineteenth century, it began in Eden. And every time Satan raises that question, he seeks to drive a wedge between the believer and the Book upon which his faith rests.

A Faith That Begins with Scripture

Our faith is not founded on textual criticism, nor on the shifting sands of academic consensus. It is founded on the words of God.

- *“The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever”* (Ps. 12:6–7).
- *“Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away”* (Matt. 24:35).
- *“The word of the Lord endureth for ever”* (1 Pet. 1:25).

If these promises mean anything, they mean that the inspired words have not vanished. They remain, preserved, purified, and available for the people of God today.

The Two Lines in History

History confirms what Scripture declares: there are two streams of Bibles.

- The **line of Antioch**: the Received Text, the Masoretic Hebrew, the Byzantine Greek, quoted by the fathers, carried by the churches, preached in revival, and used by missionaries.
- The **line of Alexandria**: the speculative texts of Origen, the eclectic philosophies of the schools, manuscripts kept unused in libraries, riddled with contradictions and omissions.

The fruit of each line tells the story. Antioch's Bibles brought reformation, evangelism, and doctrinal clarity. Alexandria's manuscripts brought confusion, rationalism, and endless revision. By their fruits ye shall know them.

Doctrine at Stake

Time and again, the Alexandrian line diminishes Christ's deity, His blood, His virgin birth, His uniqueness as Savior. Even when doctrine survives elsewhere, the cumulative pattern erodes faith by subtraction. The Bible does not simply need to teach a doctrine somewhere, it needs to preserve *every word* God gave (Matt. 4:4).

The Myths Removed

- *Readability?* Proven false. The King James Bible averages an eighth-grade reading level, often lower than modern versions, with cadence designed for public clarity.
- *The Apocrypha?* The KJV set it apart as history, never as Scripture—unlike Vaticanus and Sinaiticus, which mingled it into the canon.
- *Revisions?* Only spelling and printing corrections. The text is the same today as it was in 1611.
- *Erasmus' so-called blunders?* Where critics claim he "added" to Revelation or "inserted" the Comma, history in fact shows preservation and purification,

BY FAITH. The church already used those readings, and later manuscript discoveries confirmed them.

Every major objection collapses under scrutiny.

God's Providence in English

The King James Bible is not inspired anew; it is **inspired words preserved and purified**. As God preserved His words through the Levites (Rom. 3:2), and as He multiplied and purified His Word through centuries of use, He has given us in English a Bible that carries forward the Masoretic Old Testament and the Received New Testament.

It is no accident that for over 300 years it was the one Bible God used to spark revival, plant churches, send missionaries, and shape the modern world. Other versions rise and fall in popularity, but the King James remains because the hand of God is upon it.

A Call to Confidence

The issue is not preference. It is faith. Either God preserved His words, or He did not. Either He purified them, or He abandoned them. Either we have a sure

foundation, or we are left to the shifting theories of scholars.

The King James Bible stands as a testimony that God kept His promises. Its text is not the work of chance or mere scholarship, it is the fruit of God's guiding hand through history. It is the Bible that bears the marks of inspiration, preservation, purification, and power. With the principles laid out in the Bible itself, we are not left to guess, but we can by faith, find that perfect word of God today.

And so we say with David:

> *"Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous judgments endureth for ever"* (Ps. 119:160).

Here, then, we rest: not on man's shifting opinions, but on the unchanging words of the living God.

We are not called to be textual critics but **Bible believers**. We believe not in the theories of men, but in the promise of God to preserve and purify His Word for every generation.

The Story's End

The young man in the pew began his journey confused and unsettled. He had heard the preaching of his pastor's

conviction but then discovered the chilling disclaimer, *"in the originals."* His heart ached: how could he build his life on a book he was told was no longer here?

But as his journey unfolded, he began to search the Scriptures themselves. There he found promise after promise: *"The words of the LORD are pure words… Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this generation for ever"* (Ps. 12:6–7). *"For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven"* (Ps. 119:89). *"Heaven and earth shall pass away, but my words shall not pass away"* (Matt. 24:35). The Bible did not only speak of inspiration in the past, it declared preservation and purification in the present. God tied His own character to His words, magnifying His Word above His name (Ps. 138:2). The young man realized the Bible itself teaches that God's words still live, still endure, still remain pure.

The next question naturally followed: if God promised to preserve His words, *where* could they be found? History answered. He traced the line of faithful transmission through Antioch, the missionary hub of the early church, through the Byzantine manuscripts copied and used by believers for centuries, through the Masoretic tradition of the Old Testament, through the Received Text of the New, and finally into the English of the King James Bible. He saw the contrast with Alexandria, where philosophy and textual tampering bred doubt and omissions. By their fruits

he discerned the difference. By faith, the principles from the word of God itself, he found the book he could trust.

His journey brought him to peace. The Bible in his lap was not `missing essential parts, nor a puzzle only scholars could reconstruct. It was the purified, preserved Word of God. What began in confusion ended in clarity; what began in doubt (yea, hath God said..?) ended in faith.

The young man could now say with confidence: *"This is the Word of God. Every word, every promise, every truth, kept by God Himself. I can live by it, raise my family by it, and trust my eternity to it."*

The journey ends where it must, with the believer living by faith ("the just shall live by faith.."), able to please God ("without faith it is impossible to please him..."), resting in the living, preserved Word of the living God —to have and to hold.

"The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever." (Isa. 40:8)

PROMISES OF SCRIPTURE

Psalm 12:6-7- The words of the LORD are pure words: as silver tried in a furnace of earth,
purified seven times. Thou shalt keep them, O LORD, thou shalt preserve them from this
generation for ever.

Psalm 78:1-8- Give ear, O my people, to my law: incline your ears to the words of my
mouth. I will open my mouth in a parable: I will utter dark sayings of old: Which we have
heard and known, and our fathers have told us. We will not hide them from their children,
shewing to the generation to come the praises of the LORD, and his strength, and his
wonderful works that he hath done. For he established a testimony in Jacob, and appointed a
law in Israel, which he commanded our fathers, that they should make them known to their
children: That the generation to come might know them, even the children which should be
born; who should arise and declare them to their children: That they might set their hope in
God, and not forget the works of God, but keep his commandments: And might not be as
their fathers, a stubborn and rebellious generation; a generation that set not their heart aright,
and whose spirit was not stedfast with God.

Psalm 105:8- He hath remembered his covenant for ever, the word which he commanded to
a thousand generations.

Psalm 119:89- For ever, O LORD, thy word is settled in heaven.

Psalm 119:111- Thy testimonies have I taken as an heritage for ever: for they are the
rejoicing of my heart.

Psalm 119:152- Concerning thy testimonies, I have known of old that thou hast founded
them for ever.

Psalm 119:160- Thy word is true from the beginning: and every one of thy righteous
judgments endureth for ever.

Proverbs 22:20-21- Have not I written to thee excellent things in counsels and knowledge,
That I might make thee know the certainty of the words of truth; that thou mightest answer
the words of truth to them that send unto thee?

Matthew 5:17-18- Think not that I am come to destroy the law, or the prophets: I am not

come to destroy, but to fulfil. For verily I say unto you, Till heaven and earth pass, one jot or
one tittle shall in no wise pass from the law, till all be fulfilled.

John 10:34-36- Jesus answered them, Is it not written in your law, I said, Ye are gods? If he
called them gods, unto whom the word of God came, and the scripture cannot be broken; Say
ye of him, whom the Father hath sanctified, and sent into the world, Thou blasphemest;
because I said, I am the Son of God?

Psalm 82:1-6- God standeth in the congregation of the mighty; he judgeth among the gods.
How long will ye judge unjustly, and accept the persons of the wicked? Selah. Defend the
poor and fatherless: do justice to the afflicted and needy. Deliver the poor and needy: rid
them out of the hand of the wicked. They know not, neither will they understand; they walk
on in darkness: all the foundations of the earth are out of course. I have said, Ye are gods;
and all of you are children of the most High.

1 Peter 1:23-25- Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word

of God, which liveth and abideth for ever. For all flesh is as grass, and all the glory of man as
the flower of grass. The grass withereth, and the flower thereof falleth away: But the word of
the Lord endureth for ever. And this is the word which by the gospel is preached unto you.

John 12:48 with Revelation 20:11-13- He that rejecteth me, and receiveth not my words,
hath one that judgeth him: the word that I have spoken, the same shall judge him in the last
day.
And I saw a great white throne, and him that sat on it, from whose face the earth and the
heaven fled away; and there was found no place for them. And I saw the dead, small and
great, stand before God; and the books were opened: and another book was opened, which is
the book of life: and the dead were judged out of those things which were written in the
books, according to their works. And the sea gave up the dead which were in it; and death
and hell delivered up the dead which were in them: and they were judged every man
according to their works.

Psalm 102:12- But thou, O LORD, shalt endure for ever; and thy remembrance unto all

generations.

Isaiah 59:21- As for me, this is my covenant with them, saith the LORD; My spirit that is
upon thee, and my words which I have put in thy mouth, shall not depart out of thy mouth,
nor out of the mouth of thy seed, nor out of the mouth of thy seed's seed, saith the LORD,
from henceforth and for ever.

Psalm 105:5 with John 17:17- Remember his marvellous works that he hath done; his
wonders, and the judgments of his mouth;
Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth.

Luke 21:33- Heaven and earth shall pass away: but my words shall not pass away.

Luke 16:16-17- The law and the prophets were until John: since that time the kingdom of
God is preached, and every man presseth into it. And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass,
than one tittle of the law to fail.

Isaiah 40:8- The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for
ever.

Psalm 33:11- The counsel of the LORD standeth for ever, the thoughts of his heart to all
generations.

Psalm 117- O praise the LORD, all ye nations: praise him, all ye people. For his merciful
kindness is great toward us: and the truth of the LORD endureth for ever. Praise ye the
LORD.

Deuteronomy 7:9- Know therefore that the LORD thy God, he is God, the faithful God,
which keepeth covenant and mercy with them that love him and keep his commandments to
a thousand generations;

Psalm 135:13 with 138:2- Thy name, O LORD, endureth for ever; and thy memorial, O
LORD, throughout all generations.
35I will worship toward thy holy temple, and praise thy name for thy lovingkindness and for
thy truth: for thou hast magnified thy word above all thy name.

1 Chronicles 16:14-15- He is the LORD our God; his judgments are in all the earth. Be ye
mindful always of his covenant; the word which he commanded to a thousand generations;

Proverbs 4:1-11- Hear, ye children, the instruction of a father, and attend to know
understanding. For I give you good doctrine, forsake ye not my law. For I was my father's
son, tender and only beloved in the sight of my mother. He taught me also, and said unto me,
Let thine heart retain my words: keep my commandments, and live. Get wisdom, get
understanding: forget it not; neither decline from the words of my mouth. Forsake her not,
and she shall preserve thee: love her, and she shall keep thee. Wisdom is the principal thing;
therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding. Exalt her, and she shall
promote thee: she shall bring thee to honour, when thou dost embrace her. She shall give to
thine head an ornament of grace: a crown of glory shall she deliver to thee. Hear, O my son,
and receive my sayings; and the years of thy life shall be many. I have taught thee in the way
of wisdom; I have led thee in right paths.

Psalm 19:7-11- The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul: the testimony of the
LORD is sure, making wise the simple. The statutes of the LORD are right, rejoicing the

heart: the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes. The fear of the LORD
is clean, enduring for ever: the judgments of the LORD are true and righteous altogether.
More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and
the honeycomb. Moreover by them is thy servant warned: and in keeping of them there is
great reward.

Psalm 18:30- As for God, his way is perfect: the word of the LORD is tried: he is a buckler
to all those that trust in him.

Proverbs 30:5-6- Every word of God is pure: he is a shield unto them that put their trust in him. Add thou not unto his words, lest he reprove thee, and thou be found a liar.

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